

OUR TOWN



Dramaturgical Materials
Compiled by Anna Jennings

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LUCINDA MATLOCK*

I went to the dances at Chandlerville,
 And played snap-out at Winchester.
 One time we changed partners,
 Driving home in the moonlight of middle June,
 And then I found Davis.
 We were married and lived together for seventy
 years,
 Enjoying, working, raising the twelve children,
 Eight of whom we lost
 Ere I had reached the age of sixty.
 I spun, I wove, I kept the house, I nursed the sick,
 I made the garden, and for holiday
 Rambled over the fields where sang the larks,
 And by Spoon River gathering many a shell,
 And many a flower and medicinal weed—
 Shouting to the wooded hills, singing to the
 green valleys.
 At ninety-six I had lived enough, that is all,
 And passed to a sweet repose.
 What is this I hear of sorrow and weariness,
 Anger, discontent and drooping hopes?
 Degenerate sons and daughters,
 Life is too strong for you—
 It takes life to love Life.

DAVIS MATLOCK*

Suppose it is nothing but the hive:
 That there are drones and workers
 And queens, and nothing but storing honey—
 (Material things as well as culture and wisdom)—
 For the next generation, this generation never
 living,
 Except as it swarms in the sun-light of youth,
 Strengthening its wings on what has been
 gathered,
 And tasting, on the way to the hive
 From the clover field, the delicate spoil.
 Suppose all this, and suppose the truth:
 That the nature of man is greater
 Than nature's need in the hive;
 And you must bear the burden of life,
 As well as the urge from your spirit's excess—
 Well, I say to live it out like a god
 Sure of immortal life, though you are in doubt,
 Is the way to live it.
 If that doesn't make God proud of you
 Then God is nothing but gravitation,
 Or sleep is the golden goal.

HUMANITIES

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Student

How the Once-Banned *Spoon River Anthology* Made a Comeback in Lewistown

Poetic justice in small-town America

Laura Wolff Scanlan

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ILLINOIS

When *Spoon River Anthology* was published in 1915, Edgar Lee Masters shattered the myth of small-town America as the bastion of American virtue. In his thinly veiled fictional town of Spoon River, situated in central Illinois near Lewistown, where Masters grew up, the honest, hardworking, chaste, and churchgoing live amidst corrupt bankers, abusive husbands, unfulfilled wives, sexual deviants, and failed dreamers.

“Although such experiences and views were part of American culture, poets had not written about them before,” says John E. Hallwas, author of *Spoon River Anthology: An Annotated Edition*.

In the groundbreaking work, Masters, a onetime law partner of Clarence Darrow, gives voice to more than two hundred deceased citizens of Spoon River who are laid to rest in Oak Hill Cemetery, known to the locals as The Hill. Freed by the shackles of life, the un-living who “sleep beneath these weeds”

confess their deepest secrets, disappointments, frustrations, joys, and warnings to the living in the form of brutally honest free verse poems. “No volume of poetry since Whitman’s *Leaves of Grass* had attempted so much or had been so original,” says Hallwas.

Each postmortem poem in the collection is titled with the name of the citizen who reveals some truth about their daily existence in Spoon River. Masters gleaned tidbits of stories and gossip he heard during the time he spent in Lewistown and nearby Petersburg, where his grandparents lived. In some cases, Masters barely changed their names. Henry Phipps was really banker Henry Phelps. Harry Wilmans was Henry Wilmans. In a few instances, he used real names, such as William H. Herndon, the law partner of Abraham Lincoln, and Anne Rutledge, considered Lincoln’s first love.

Meant to be read as a novel, the reader is required to piece together narratives from single lines and fragments contained in individual poems. Minerva Jones tells us she was raped by Butch Weldy and died during an abortion. Doctor Meyers, the abortionist, blames Minerva for his own death in jail saying, “I tried to help her out.” Mrs. Meyers, the doctor’s wife, believes her husband deserved the town’s scorn for breaking “the law human and divine.” Butch Weldy, on the other hand, never mentions the rape but tells us he “got religion and steadied down.”

The book was a literary sensation and huge commercial success. Carl Sandburg wrote in the *Little Review*, “The people whose faces look out from the pages of the book are the people of life itself, each trait of them as plain or as mysterious as in the old home valley where the writer came from. Such a writer and book are realized here.” Ezra Pound rejoiced in the *London Egoist*: “At last the American West has produced a poet . . . capable of dealing with life directly, without circumlocution, without resonant meaningless phrases. Ready to say what he has to say, and shut up when he [has] said it.” It was an international best-seller, reported to have sold 80,000 copies in four years. Masters himself boasted that it “broke the record in America for the sale of a book of verse.”

Back in Lewistown, however, the villagers were not so enthusiastic. On the contrary, they were furious with “that scoundrel Masters.” “After all,” says Hallwas, “he often exposed the troubled lives of people.” Even though most names were fictitious, everyone in town knew exactly who he was talking about. Because of this, the book was immediately banned from schools and libraries in the area, including the Lewistown library, where Masters’s mother worked as a librarian. Although the book was not available in the area, some found a way to obtain a secret copy, which they talked about only in whispers.

Masters was interested in writing from a very young age, but was encouraged to follow in his father’s footsteps as a lawyer. He was admitted to the bar in 1891 and left Lewistown to build a law practice in Chicago. In his off time, he wrote poetry and plays with little success. Masters became acquainted with

writers who would become known as the Chicago Renaissance, including Sandburg, Sherwood Anderson, and Theodore Dreiser, who Masters honors with a poem titled “Theodore the Poet” in the *Anthology*.

After reading *Epigrams from Greek Anthology*, Masters experimented with the epigram form and submitted some poems he wrote to *Reedy's Mirror*, a literary magazine in St. Louis. The poems were serialized in 1914 under the pseudonym Webster Ford for fear of damaging Masters's law practice. His real identity was revealed later that year by *Mirror* editor William Reedy, who asserted Masters's work was “a great work of literary art.”

With the success of *Spoon River Anthology*, Masters left his law practice to write full time and moved to New York in 1920. Although he would write more than 50 books, including novels, plays, poetry, and biographies of Mark Twain, Walt Whitman, and Abraham Lincoln, he never equaled the success he had with *Spoon River Anthology*.

The wounds have healed in Lewistown as successive generations joined their family and friends on The Hill. The book's banning was lifted in 1974. Masters and *Spoon River Anthology* are now celebrated throughout the year in Lewistown. To commemorate its 100-year anniversary, Lewistown is hosting several events, including Oak Hill Cemetery tours, exhibitions, theatrical performances, and walking tours. As part of the Illinois Humanities Speakers Bureau, Paddy Lynn, Jon Lynn, and Patti Ecker perform dramatic readings throughout the state, and Hallwas gives his talk, “Poets of Community and Human Struggle: Edgar Lee Masters and Carl Sandburg.”

Masters died in 1950 and is buried at Oakland Cemetery in Petersburg. In 1970, the U.S. Postal Service issued a stamp in his honor.

The work continues to stay relevant for its treatment of the human condition says Hallwas. It has never been out of print, has been adapted for stage and screen, taught in acting classes, translated into numerous languages, and phrases from “Alexander Throckmorton” were quoted by Pope Francis during his recent visit to America.

About the author

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Our Town Glossary

Compiled by Kamilah Bush for Triad Stage's 2018 production:

<https://sites.google.com/view/ourtowndramaturgy/glossary?authuser=0>

Canuck – A Canadian, specifically a French Canadian - this term is most often a slur.

Presbyterian – A protestant denomination originating in the British Isles and Scotland in the 16th century. Presbyterian theology typically emphasizes the sovereignty of God, the authority of the Scriptures, and the necessity of grace through faith in Christ. Presbyterians distinguish themselves from other denominations by doctrine, institutional organization (or "church order") and worship; often using a "Book of Order" to regulate common practice and order.

Methodist – A protestant denomination originating in the British Empire during the 18th century. Most Methodists teach that Jesus Christ, the Son of God, died for all of humanity and that salvation is available for all.

Unitarian – A Christian theological practice, originating in the mid-16th century, which rejects the Holy Trinity, asserting that Jesus was inspired by God in his moral teachings, and he is a savior, but he was a normal human being and not a deity or God incarnate.

Holla' – "Hollow," a small rising valley region between two hills or mountains; often containing a creek

Hollyhock



Heliotrope



Burdock



Butternut Tree



Congregational Church – Protestant denomination originating in the Plymouth and Massachusetts Bay colonies in 1648. Congregational churches in the Reformed tradition practice congregationalist church governance, in which each congregation independently and autonomously runs its own affairs.

"...it always tells me when it's going to rain." – There are theories that changes in barometric pressure in the weather, as well as temperatures and humidity can trigger chronic joint pain sufferers' aches.

Massachusetts Tech – Refers to what we know as MIT, a private research university in Cambridge, Massachusetts, United States. Founded in 1861 in response to the increasing industrialization of the United States, MIT adopted a European polytechnic university model and stressed laboratory instruction in applied science and engineering.

"...the war broke out." – Refers to WWI - also known as the First World War, the Great War, or the War to End All Wars, was a global war originating in Europe that lasted from 28 July 1914 to 11 November 1918. More than 70 million military personnel, including 60 million Europeans, were mobilized in one of the largest wars in history

Separator – a centrifugal device that separates milk into cream and skimmed milk. Separation was commonly performed on farms in the past. Most farmers milked a few cows, usually by hand, and separated milk. Some of the skimmed milk was consumed while the rest was used to feed calves and pigs. Enough cream was saved to make butter, and the excess was sold.

Forty Winks – to take a nap for a short period of time (usually not in bed), or to take a short sleep during the day

Strawberry phosphates – a type of beverage that has a tangy or sour taste. These beverages became popular among children in the 1870s in the United States. Phosphate beverages were made with fruit flavorings, egg, malt, or wine. In the 1900s, the beverages became popular, and fruit-flavored phosphate sodas were served at soda fountains.

"String some of these beans" – A process by which green beans are prepared before cooking or canning. Grasp the end of a bean firmly between your thumb and index finger. Twist the tip down toward its seam with a quick, even motion. A fresh bean should snap readily. Draw the broken tip down along the seam to remove the tough fiber that may be present. Most green beans available today do not have this "string," but heirloom varieties may. Snap off the other end of the bean in the same way. Discard the snapped-off ends and any fibers in the small bowl.



Highboy – A tall chest of drawers on legs

Napoleon – A French statesman and military leader who was the Emperor of the French from 1804-1815 (briefly) and took control of most of the European continent in that time.

Antietam – The Battle of Antietam (ant-EE-dum), or as it is known in much of the South, the Battle of Sharpsburg, took place on September 17, 1862 near Sharpsburg, (just over 400 miles from where Grover's Corners is supposed to be). It is the single bloodiest day in American history, with a death toll of nearly 23,000. It was also the first battle of the U.S. Civil War to take place on Union soil.

Pleistocene granite – Granite having formed during the earlier half of the Quaternary Period, beginning about two million years ago and ending 10,000 years ago, characterized by widespread glacial ice and the advent of modern humans.

Appalachian Range – Appalachia is a large expanse of the North American continent stretching 205,000-square-miles from southern New York to northern Mississippi and touching parts of 13 states. The region is home to approximately 25 million people in 420 counties. The Appalachian Mountain range began forming nearly 480 million years ago and its highest group is Mount Mitchell in North Carolina at 6,684 feet (2,037 m), which is the highest point in the United States east of the Mississippi River.

Devonian Basalt – a geologic period and system of the Paleozoic, spanning 60 million years from the end of the Silurian, 419.2 million years ago (Mya), to the beginning of the Carboniferous, 358.9 Mya. It is named after Devon, England, where rocks from this period were first studied.

Mesozoic Shale – a fine-grained, clastic sedimentary rock composed of mud that is a mix of flakes of clay minerals and tiny fragments (silt-sized particles) of other minerals, especially quartz and calcite having formed during an interval of geological time from about 252 to 66 million years ago.

Sandstone – a clastic sedimentary rock composed mainly of sand-sized (0.0625 to 2 mm) mineral particles or rock fragments.

Amerindian – another term for American Indian, used chiefly in anthropological and linguistic contexts.

Cotahatchee – This Native American tribe appears to be Wilder's own invention. The tribe in the area where Grover's Corners is set would have been the Missisquoi or the Abenaki people.

English brachiocephalic – May refer to *brachycephalic* which is a relatively broad, short skull (usually with the breadth at least 80 percent of the length).

MacPhearson's Gauge – Logan Grant MacPherson (1863-1925) was "an authority on population figures". MacPherson "was employed by American railroads as a statistician, and his computations were used by government and commercial agencies." Presumably 6.032 people die each year in Grover's Corners? The birth and mortality rates are constant, so the same number of people is born each year as dies.

Board of Selectmen – Historically, in most New England towns, the adult voting population gathered annually in a town meeting to act as the local legislature, approving budgets and laws. Day-to-day operations were originally left to individual oversight, but when towns became too large for individuals to handle such workloads, they would elect an executive board of, literally, select(ed) men to run things for them. Typically,

there are three men who are selectmen and, basically, they comprise the executive branch of the town's government.

Robinson Crusoe – Published in 1719, this novel tells the story of the titular character who has been a castaway for 28 years on a remote island near Trinidad.

Monroe Doctrine – a piece of U.S. foreign policy dating from 1823. At a time when many South American nations were gaining independence from Spain and Portugal, the Monroe Doctrine held that any European intervention in North or South America would be considered an act of aggression against the United States. This was not United States law per se but rather Executive policy.

Louisiana Purchase – The Louisiana Territory was purchased 1803 from France under the presidency of Thomas Jefferson. The purchase was of 828,000 square miles.

Telegraph – The electric telegraph was developed earlier but really became a technology in common use in the 1830s. It sent electric currents along wires in order to relay messages. Needles could point to specific letters and could be interpreted by operators. With Morse code, this could work faster, but it was still dependent on operators. By the turn of the century, electric telegraphs were able to work at speeds of (a very fast) 70 words a minute.

"Vermont for the marble" – New Hampshire does actually have plenty of marble, but the good marble is always thought to come from Vermont. It is a bit of a point of pride for Vermonters and a source of irritation for any resident of New Hampshire, thus the stage-manager's "sorry to say".

Silicate glue – They are covering the reading material in sodium silicate in order to keep out air and other things that will rot the paper.

Treaty of Versailles – World War I officially ended with the signing of the Treaty of Versailles on June 28, 1919. Negotiated among the Allied powers with little participation by Germany, its 15 parts and 440 articles reassigned German boundaries and assigned liability for reparations.

Lindbergh Flight – Charles Lindbergh, a 25-year-old U.S. Air Mail pilot, emerged suddenly from virtual obscurity to instantaneous world fame as the result of his solo, non-stop flight on May 20–21, 1927 from Roosevelt Field in Garden City, Long Island to Le Bourget Field in (here it is again) Paris, France. The flight was a distance of nearly 3,600 statute miles; Lindbergh flew in a single-seat, single-engine plane called the Spirit of St. Louis. As a result of this flight, Lindbergh was the first person in history to be in New York one day and Paris the next. Lindbergh, a U.S. Army Air Corps Reserve officer, was also awarded the nation's highest military decoration, the Medal of Honor, for this historic exploit

Potato weather – Potato planting requires timing between hard freezes and hot temperatures. Depending on local weather, most gardeners plant in March, April, or May, and expect a harvest about four months later, starting to dig new potatoes about two to three weeks after plants flower.

Cicero's Orations – *O tempora, O mores!* The Catiline Orations, as they are now known, were speeches given in 63 BCE by Marcus Tullius Cicero, the consul of Rome, exposing to the Roman Senate the plot of Lucius Sergius Catilina and his allies to overthrow the government. The famous opening lines are: *How long, O Catiline, will you abuse our patience? And for how long will that madness of yours mock us? To what end will your unbridled audacity hurl itself?*

Parson – a beneficed member of the clergy; a rector or a vicar.

Overshoes – There are two basic types. One is like an oversize shoe or low boot made of thick rubber with a heavy sole and instep, designed for heavy-duty use. The other one is of much thinner, more flexible material, more like a rubber slipper, designed solely for protection against the wet rather than for extensive walking.

Philo System – The Philo System of Progressive Poultry Keeping is a real book written by Edgar Philo and published in 1908 which advocates improved chicken management by informing readers of precise details of chicken management. He advocated, for instance, that chickens be kept in small flocks of 10 instead of large flocks of sixty. He noted that 10 hens would lay 60 eggs in 7 days, or one egg a day per week per hen with one day off. But a large coop of 100 chickens would not lay 600 eggs a week; they were too stressed. Dividing them back into small groups increased egg production to the fabled 600 eggs per week.

Ice Cream Soda – Similar to an ice cream float, wherein soda water, syrups and ice cream are mixed together in a dessert drink.

State Agriculture College – Now called the University of New Hampshire, the New Hampshire College of Agriculture and the Mechanic Arts was originally attached to Dartmouth College and was housed in Hanover NH. In 1893 it moved to Durham,

Cattle judging – the process of judging a series of cattle and pronouncing a first-, second- and third-place animal based on each animal's individual traits compared to that of the others. Most cattle judging occurs in show rings at agricultural shows. Judgments on cattle are ultimately based on which animal is worth the most profit. There are many fine points to cattle judging. In a beef animal, for example, it is desirable to have a large animal with muscle development. In a dairy cow, however, the judge would look for characteristics that would help to produce the best possible milk. When judging cattle, there is an overjudge, who looks at all of the cattle and puts them in order of 'best' animal to 'worst' animal.

"The go-cart" – a small carriage for young children to ride in; stroller. or a small framework with casters, wheels, etc., in which children learn to walk; walker.

Mountain Laurel



Lilacs



Daughters of the American Revolution - A lineage-based membership service organization for women who are directly descended from a person involved in the United States' struggle for independence. They promote historic preservation, education and patriotism.

Mayflower – an English ship that famously transported the first English Puritans, known today as the Pilgrims, from Plymouth, England to the New World in 1620. There were 102 passengers, and the crew is estimated to have been about 30, but the exact number is unknown. This voyage has become an iconic story in some of the earliest annals of American history, with its story of death and of survival in the harsh New England winter environment. The culmination of the voyage in the signing of the Mayflower Compact was an event which established a rudimentary form of democracy, with each member contributing to the welfare of the community

Lumbago – lower back pain or pain in the lumbar region of the spine.

Livery stable – A livery stable was a stable where horses, teams, and wagons were for hire, but also where privately owned horses could be boarded for a short time, often attached to a hotel or boarding house. The livery stable was a necessary institution of every US American town. In addition to providing vital transportation service, the livery was the source of hay, grain, coal, and wood. Because of the stench, noise, and vermin that surrounded the livery, cities and towns attempted to control their locations and activities. Because of their location on a town's outskirts, livery stables were often the scene of gambling and cockfighting, and they were often condemned as sources of vice. With the advent of the automobile after 1910, livery stables all over the country quietly disappeared.

Hamilton College – a private, nonsectarian liberal arts college located in the village of Clinton, New York, in the Mohawk Valley foothills of the Adirondack Mountains. Founded as an academy in 1793, it was chartered as Hamilton College in 1812 (named for charter trustee Alexander Hamilton).

Locations

Canton, Ohio – city in and the county seat of Stark County, Ohio, United States. Founded in 1805 alongside the Middle and West Branches of Nimishillen Creek, Canton became a heavy manufacturing center because of its numerous railroad lines. However, its status in that regard began to decline during the late 20th century, as shifts in the manufacturing industry led to the relocation or repositioning of many factories. After this decline, the city's industry diversified into the service economy, including retailing, education, finance and healthcare.

Concord, New Hampshire – The capital of New Hampshire (pron. CON-curd): in the Southern third of the state but about halfway between the eastern and western borders

Boston, Massachusetts – the capital city and most populous municipality of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts. Boston is one of the oldest cities in the United States, founded on the Shawmut Peninsula in 1630 by Puritan settlers from England.

Gettysburg – A town in Pennsylvania where the Battle of Gettysburg took place - fought July 1–3, 1863, by Union and Confederate forces during the American Civil War. The battle involved the largest number of casualties of the entire war and is often described as the war's turning point. Union Maj. Gen. George Meade's Army of the Potomac defeated attacks by Confederate Gen. Robert E. Lee's Army of Northern Virginia, halting Lee's invasion of the North.

Contoocook – a village and census-designated place within the town of Hopkinton in Merrimack County, New Hampshire. The village is named after the Contoocook River that runs through it. The name Contoocook came from the Pennacook tribe of Native Americans and means "place of the river near pines".

Lake Sunapee – Lake Sunapee (SUN-uh-pee) is in West Central New Hampshire. North of Grover's Corners and perhaps a bit west of it.

Lake Winnepesaukee – Lake Winnepesaukee (winnipuh-SAW-kee) is much farther north of Sunapee and farther east in the true center of the state. It is also much bigger

White Mountains – The White Mountains cover most of New Hampshire beginning in the south from around Lake Sunapee and curving north of Lake Winnepesaukee. They are a part of the Appalachian Range. These mountains are a very big deal in New Hampshire, and tourists come from miles away to see the leaves turn color in the autumn.

Mt. Washington – Mt. Washington is the highest peak in the Northeastern United States and is a part of the White Mountains. It is, it must be noted, extremely far from where Grover's Corners is supposed to be near the Massachusetts/New Hampshire border.

North Conway/Conway – Towns far to the east in New Hampshire. Conway and North Conway lie close to the Maine border just south of Mount Washington

Mt. Monadnock – Mt. Monadnock (muh-NAD-nock) is famous for appearing in the writings of Emerson and Thoreau. This mountain is surrounded by the towns mentioned in the play (Jaffrey, East Jaffrey, Peterborough, Dublin), as well as by Troy and Marlborough. All of this area of New Hampshire is much closer to the Massachusetts border

Jaffrey – a town in Cheshire County, New Hampshire located along the Contoocook River at the junction of U.S. Route 202 and New Hampshire routes 124 and 137.

East Jaffrey – a historic district running roughly along NH Route 124 (Main Street) through Jaffrey, New Hampshire. It encompasses what is now the economic and civic heart of the town, centered on the Jaffrey Mills and the crossing of the Contoocook River by Route 124.

Peterborough – a town in Hillsborough County, New Hampshire located along the Contoocook River at the junction of U.S. Route 202 and New Hampshire Route 101. The community is 38 miles west of Manchester and 72 miles northwest of Boston.

Dublin – a town in Cheshire County, New Hampshire, The northern slopes of Mount Monadnock occupy the southern part of town. The highest point in Dublin is along Monadnock's northeast ridge. Roughly the western half of Dublin lies within the Connecticut River watershed, drained by tributaries of the Ashuelot River, with the eastern half located in the Merrimack River watershed, drained by tributaries of the Contoocook River. The town is crossed by New Hampshire Route 101 and New Hampshire Route 137.

Woodlawn – also known as Woodlawn Heights, is an Irish American working class neighborhood at the very north end of the borough of the Bronx, in New York City

Brooklyn – Most likely a reference to the Cemetery of the Evergreens in Brooklyn and Queens. In the late 1920s it was the busiest cemetery in New York City

Crawford Notch – a major pass through the White Mountains of New Hampshire, located almost entirely within the town of Hart's Location. Roughly half of that town is contained in Crawford Notch State Park. The high point of the notch, at approximately 1,900 feet (580 m) above sea level, is at the southern end of the town of Carroll, near the Crawford Depot train station and Saco Lake, the source of the Saco River, which flows southward through the steep-sided notch. North of the high point of the notch, Crawford Brook flows more gently northwest to the Ammonoosuc River, a tributary of the Connecticut River.

Buffalo, NY – The second-largest city in the U.S. state of New York and the 81st-most populous city in the United States. The Buffalo area was inhabited before the 17th century by the Iroquois tribe and later by French settlers. The city grew significantly in the 19th and 20th centuries as a result of immigration, the construction of the Erie Canal, the building of railroads and its close proximity to Lake Erie, providing an abundance of fresh water and an ample trade route to the Midwestern United States, while grooming its economy for the grain, steel and automobile industries that dominated the city's economy during the 20th century.

Clinton, NY. – the Village of Clinton in Oneida County in central New York: the site of Hamilton College.

History

POP Culture: 1900

ICONS: "Wright Brothers, Pablo Picasso, Ford Model T



- Kodak® introduces the "Brownie" camera in February 1900.
- On September 6, 1901, Leon Czolgosz shot President William McKinley. He died at 2:15 a.m. on September 14 and Vice-President Theodore Roosevelt was sworn in as president later that day.
- Composer and musician Scott Joplin publishes *The Entertainer* in 1902.
- The January 22, 1903, Hay-Herran Treaty grants the United States a renewable lease in perpetuity from Colombia on the land proposed for the Panama Canal.
- On February 14, 1903, the U.S. Census Bureau becomes part of the new U.S. Department of Commerce and Labor.
- The first silent film, *The Great Train Robbery*, debuts in 1903.
- Orville and Wilbur Wright are first to fly a controlled, powered, and sustained heavier-than-air airplane at Kitty Hawk, NC, on December 17, 1903.
- Prominent civil and women's rights leader Susan B. Anthony dies on March 13, 1906.
- The first underground portion of the New York City subway opens on October 27, 1904.
- At 5:12 a.m. on April 18, 1906, the "Great San Francisco Earthquake" strikes.
- Artist Pablo Picasso introduces Cubism in 1907.
- An explosion in West Virginia's Monongah Mine on December 6, 1907, becomes the nation's worst industrial disaster. The "official" number of deaths was 362 adult and child miners, but later estimates exceed 500.
- Henry Ford begins production of the Model T in 1908.
- The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) is founded on February 12, 1909.
- The U.S. Mint introduces the "Lincoln Head" penny in 1909.

The 1900 Census

U.S. Resident Population:	76,212,168
Population per square mile of land area:	21.5
Percent increase of population from 1890 to 1900:	21.0
Official Enumeration Date:	June 1
Number of States:	45
Cost:	\$11,854,000
Cost per Capita (cents):	15.5
Total Pages in Published Reports:	10,925
Number of Enumerators:	52,871
Census Bureau Director:	<u>William Rush Merriam</u>
Number of Questions Asked:	28

10 Largest Urban Places

Rank	Place	Population
1	New York City, NY	3,437,202
2	Chicago, IL	1,698,575
3	Philadelphia, PA	1,293,697
4	St. Louis, MO	575,238
5	Boston, MA	560,892
6	Baltimore, MD	508,957
7	Cleveland, OH	381,768
8	Buffalo, NY	352,387
9	San Francisco, CA	342,782
10	Cincinnati, OH	325,902



Timeline: 1900s

Years: 1900 - 1909

Subject: History, modern history (1700 to 1945)

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Year	Event
1900	Daimler cars develop a new brand using the name Mercedes, that of the ten-year-old daughter of the investor and distributor Emil Jellinek
	Giacomo Puccini's <i>Tosca</i> brings in the new century with a January premiere in Rome
	The faction founded in Bohemia by Tomas Masaryk becomes known as the Progressive party
	Isadora Duncan dances professionally for the first time in Europe in London's Lyceum Theatre
	Paul Kruger flees after the British take Pretoria and annexe both the Boer republics
	Puerto Ricans are granted limited democracy in a bill of rights introduced after two years of US military occupation
	Frank Baum introduces children to Oz, in his book <i>The Wonderful Wizard of Oz</i>
	Scottish music-hall artist Harry Lauder makes his first London appearance at Gatti's music hall in Westminster
	David Belasco's play <i>Madame Butterfly</i> has its premiere in New York, and is subsequently seen in London by Giacomo Puccini
	The Conservatives win an increased majority during the Boer War, in what becomes known as the 'khaki election'
	Charles Rennie Mackintosh and his wife exhibit together at the Sezession show in Vienna
	Enrique Granados completes the ten piano pieces forming his <i>Danzas españolas</i>
	Keir Hardie is returned to parliament for Merthyr Tydfil, beginning a long and close link between the Labour party and Wales.

The relief of Mafeking ends a long siege which brings fame to the British commander of the garrison, Robert Baden-Powell

Rubber brings prosperity to Manaus, thousands of miles up the Amazon

After a prodigiously productive career as novelist and journalist, Stephen Crane dies of tuberculosis at the age of 28

Hostility to foreign intrusion erupts in China with the Boxer Rising

Harvey Firestone sets up the Firestone Tire and Rubber Company in Akron, Ohio

Joshua Slocum publishes *Sailing Alone Around the World*, an account of his famous 1895-8 circumnavigation

The Bayer company in Germany sells aspirin in the form of water-soluble tablets, the first medication of its kind

Ferdinand Zeppelin's first dirigible makes its test flight from a floating hangar on the Lake of Constance

Charles Stewart Rolls wins the Automobile Club's Thousand Mile Trial in a 12 horse-power Panhard

Jack London's first collection of stories, *The Son of the Wolf*, brings him a wide readership

The British government assumes direct responsibility for the entire region of Nigeria, previously entrusted to a commercial company

Jean Sibelius's *Finlandia* stirs national instincts in Helsinki

Theodore Dreiser's first novel, *Sister Carrie*, receives no publicity because his publisher, Frank Doubleday, considers it immoral

Sigmund Freud publishes one of his most significant works, *The Interpretation of Dreams*

Australia's Salvation Army produces an ambitious presentation of film and slides in *Soldiers of the Cross*

The Irish Parliamentary Party, which split after the Parnell divorce case, reunites under the leadership of John Redmond

More than 8000 people die when a hurricane demolishes the seaside resort of Galveston in Texas

The American League emerges from baseball's Western League, before going national in 1901

The Voice of the People is the first of Ellen Glasgow's novels set in her native state, Virginia

Anton Chekhov's play *Uncle Vanya* is directed by Stanislavsky at the Moscow Art Theatre

Wilbur and Orville Wright test a biplane glider at Kitty Hawk in North Carolina

In the US presidential election William McKinley wins a second term on a simple platform, promising 'the full dinner pail'

Edward Elgar writes the oratorio *Dream of Gerontius*, setting Cardinal Newman's poem of the same title

Gustave Charpentier's opera *Louise* has Paris premiere at the Opéra-Comique

German physicist Max Planck proposes the revolutionary concept of the quantum theory

Lenin and comrades launch in Munich a radical newspaper, *Iskra* ('the spark')

Joseph Conrad publishes his novel *Lord Jim* about a life of failure and redemption in the far East

Humbert I, the king of Italy, is assassinated by an Italian-American anarchist, Gaetano Bresci

The Welsh painter Augustus John becomes Britain's most famous bohemian

The Russian physiologist Ivan Pavlov keeps dogs alive almost indefinitely by severely curtailing their bodily functions

1901

Six separate Australian colonies combine to form the independent Commonwealth of Australia

Queen Victoria dies at Osborne House, on the Isle of Wight, after 63 years on the throne

Edward VII is already 59 when he succeeds his mother, Victoria, as Britain's monarch

Vast crowds line the streets for the Milan funeral of a national hero, the 87-year-old composer Giuseppe Verdi

Thousands of women and children die in the concentration camps used by the British army for displaced Boer families

Photographer Eadweard Muybridge extends the range of his studies with *Human Figure in Motion*

Rusalka, by the Czech composer Anton Dvořák, is performed in Prague

Thomas Mann's first novel, *Buddenbrooks*, brings him immediate success

A stele is found at Susa, in Iran, giving the text of the Code of Hammurabi

Charles Voysey completes a house for himself, The Orchard, at Chorley Wood in Hertfordshire

Beatrix Potter publishes at her own expense *The Tale of Peter Rabbit*

Ransome Eli Olds manufactures the Curved Dash Oldsmobile on assembly line principles in Detroit

The concept of instant coffee is developed in Chicago by the Japanese American chemist Satori Kato

Rudyard Kipling's experiences of India are put to good use in his novel *Kim*

A change of palette by Pablo Picasso takes him into what becomes known as his Blue Period

The British batsman C.B. Fry hits a record six consecutive centuries in first-class cricket

Frank Lloyd Wright designs low residential buildings, suitable for the plains around Chicago, and calls them Prairie Houses

The Austrian biochemist Karl Landsteiner discovers that human blood is of varying types

The first of Edward Elgar's five *Pomp and Circumstance* marches has a trio section that becomes "Land of Hope and Glory"

Sergei Rachmaninov's Second Piano Concerto gives him renewed confidence after the disaster of his First Symphony in 1897

The Texas oil industry is launched with the discovery of the 75,000-barrel-a-day Lucas Gusher near Beaumont

Frederick Delius completes his opera *A Village Romeo and Juliet*, but it is not performed until 1907 in Berlin

Charles Rennie Mackintosh designs the interior of Miss Cranston's Ingram Street Tea Rooms in Glasgow

Anton Chekhov's *Three Sisters* has its premiere at the Moscow Art Theatre, directed by Stanislavsky

Robert Falcon Scott sets off in the *Discovery* on his first expedition to the Antarctic

Australia passes an Immigration Restriction Act to underpin the White Australia policy

Frank Norris publishes *The Octopus*, the first of a projected trilogy of novels set in Southern California

President McKinley is assassinated by an anarchist when visiting the Pan-American exhibition in Buffalo

Vice President Theodore Roosevelt becomes US president on McKinley's death

The 1901 census reveals that the population of the United Kingdom has almost doubled in 50 years, to 38 million

Frank Hornby begins to market in Britain his immensely successful Meccano kits

Guglielmo Marconi transmits a radio message in Morse code 2100 miles, from Poldhu in Cornwall to St John's in Newfoundland

Edith Wharton's publishes her first full-length novel, *The Valley of Decision*

Ebenezer Howard republishes his earlier book of 1898 as *Garden Cities of Tomorrow*

Venezuela defaults on European interest payments and is soon threatened by British, German and Italian warships

Rudyard Kipling publishes his *Just So Stories for Little Children*

US philosopher William James publishes his influential book *The Varieties of Religious Experience*

In his pamphlet *What is to be done?* Lenin argues for early action to promote revolution

Alfred Stieglitz and other US photographers launch the Photo-Secession movement

Helen Keller's *The Story of My Life* begins publication in serial form

French automobile pioneer Leon Serpollet sets a new land speed record, driving a steam car at 75 mph along the Promenade des Anglais in Nice

North Carolina pharmacist Caleb Bradham launches the Pepsi-Cola company in a back room of his shop

A.E. Kennelly and Oliver Heaviside independently see the link between the atmosphere and the behaviour of radio waves

The play *Cathleen ni Houlihan*, by W.B. Yeats and Lady Gregory, fosters Irish nationalism

The US Congress makes the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 permanent, without the need for ten-year renewals

Cuba becomes independent after three years of US military rule, with certain restrictions imposed by the Platt Amendment of 1901

A treaty at Vereeniging ends the Boer War and brings the Boer republics under British control

Charles Pathé develops film facilities capable of mass production, in Vincennes near Paris

Irish politician Arthur Griffith launches Sinn Féin, as an organization campaigning for a strong and independent Ireland

After the defeat of neighbouring Transvaal in the Boer War, the British take sole control of Swaziland

'Land of Hope and Glory' features in its lasting form as the finale of Elgar's *Coronation Ode* for Edward VII

The three-year Philippine-American War is brought to an end, and the Philippines become a US colony

The Tale of Peter Rabbit is published commercially, a year after being first printed by Beatrix Potter at her own expense

Lord Salisbury resigns as British prime minister and is succeeded by his nephew, A.J. Balfour

The sculptor Aristide Maillol has his first one-man exhibition, at the Galerie Vollard in Paris

Augustus John meets his favourite subject Dorothy McNeill, to whom he gives the Gypsy name Dorelia

John Masefield's poem 'Sea Fever' is published in *Salt-Water Ballads*

Hughie Cannon writes 'Bill Bailey Won't You Please Come Home' for a minstrel, John Queen

Maxim Gorky's play *The Lower Depths* is performed at the Moscow Art Theatre

Conan Doyle's *The Hound of the Baskervilles* begins publication in serial form

W.B. Yeats heads a group of writers and directors in establishing the Irish National Theatre Society

Claude Debussy's opera *Pelléas et Mélisande* has its premiere in Paris

Henry James publishes the first of his three last novels, *The Wings of the Dove*

French film pioneer Georges Méliès uses trick effects for his film *Journey to the Moon*

Gustav Mahler marries Alma, daughter of the artist Emil Jakob Schindler

The tenor Enrico Caruso cuts his first phonograph records in Milan, beginning an immensely successful recording career

William K. Vanderbilt drives the first internal-combustion car to win the land speed record, at 76 mph at Ables in France

Brooklyn shopkeepers Morris and Rose Michtom have a huge success with their presidential 'Teddy's Bear'

The first Aswan dam, at this time the world's largest, is completed on the Nile

Joseph Conrad publishes a collection of stories including *Heart of Darkness*, a sinister tale based partly on his own journey up the Congo

The English painter G.F. Watts is made a founding member of the Order of Merit

1903

The Wizard of Oz, based on the book by Frank Baum, opens on Broadway as a musical to huge success

Cuba is forced to accept a permanent US military presence in Guantanamo Bay

US author Jack London publishes a novel, *The Call of the Wild*, in which a huge pet dog has alarming adventures

Lenin's supporters become known as the Bolsheviks ('majority') as opposed to the Mensheviks ('minority') after a split at the party's Second Congress

German surgeon Georg Clemens Perthes discovers, in Leipzig, that X-rays can inhibit cancer

Sibelius writes *Valse Triste* as incidental music to a play, *Kuolema*, by his brother-in-law Arvid Järnefelt

Gertrude Stein leaves the USA to share with her brother an apartment in Paris that soon becomes a literary and artistic salon

Emmeline Pankhurst founds the Women's Social and Political Union to fight for women's political rights in the UK

José Batlle is elected president of Uruguay and proves to be a visionary politician

Erskine Childers has a best-seller in *The Riddle of the Sands*, a thriller about a planned German invasion of Britain

King Alexander and Queen Draga of Serbia are murdered in their palace by army officers

In a paper to a congress in Madrid, on the 'psychology and psychopathology of animals', Ivan Pavlov announces his discovery of the conditioned reflex

Henry James publishes *The Ambassadors*, the second of his three last novels written in rapid succession

Ernest Rutherford and Frederick Soddy identify the phenomenon of radioactive half-life

Edward VII, the first British monarch to travel to India, holds a great coronation *darbar* in Delhi

Roger Casement, British consul in the Congo Free State, discovers appalling abuses by Belgian companies

Edwin S. Porter directs *The Great Train Robbery*, providing a big commercial success for Thomas Edison's film company

Giuseppe Sarto is elected pope and takes the name Pius X

British philosopher G.E. Moore publishes *Principia Ethica*, an attempt to apply logic to ethics

A US warship appears off the coast of Panama in support of rebels declaring an independent republic

Maurice Ravel sets to music romantic oriental poems by Tristan Klingsor in his song-cycle *Shéhérazade*

The Colombian government rejects the Hay-Herrán treaty with the US on the Panama canal, thus prompting the break-away of Panama

William Harley and three Davidson brothers begin the commercial production in Milwaukee of motorcycles, but complete only three by the end of the year

US author W.E.B. Du Bois publishes his first collection of essays, *The Souls of Black Folk*

Dutch physiologist Willem Einthoven invents the galvanometer, or electrocardiograph, for recording the electrical impulses within the heart muscle

The Pit, the second volume of an uncompleted trilogy by US novelist Frank Norris, is published posthumously

The first World Series is played between nine leading baseball teams from the National League and the American League

Britain's first national motor show is organized at the Crystal Palace, moving two years later to Olympia

Charles Rennie Mackintosh completes the Willow Tea Rooms in Glasgow for Miss Cranston

The USA is granted exclusive control in perpetuity of a ten-mile corridor across Panama, suitable for a canal

Italian tenor Enrico Caruso makes his US debut at the New York Metropolitan Opera

Work begins on England's first garden city, at Letchworth, based on the theories of Ebenezer Howard

Orville Wright travels 40 yards in the first successful powered flight, at Kitty Hawk in North Carolina

The annual Prix Goncourt is established in France, in accordance with the will of Edmond de Goncourt

1904

Anton Chekhov's last play, *The Cherry Orchard*, is staged by Stanislavsky just a few months before the author's death

Leos Janacek's opera *Jenufa*, based on a play by Gabriela Preissová, has its premiere in Brno

Finnish architect Gottlieb Eliel Saarinen wins the competition to build Helsinki's railway station

J.M. Synge's play *Riders to the Sea* has its premiere at the Molesworth Hall in Dublin

Charles Stewart Rolls, a keen driver, meets electrical engineer Henry Royce in a historic encounter in Manchester

A violent uprising by Herero warriors in South West Africa targets male Germans of military age

Giacomo Puccini's opera *Madama Butterfly* falls victim at La Scala to claque paid for by rivals

A surprise Japanese attack on Russian warships in Port Arthur launches the Russo-Japanese War for influence in Far East

John Christian Watson becomes Australia's first Labor prime minister, leading a minority government that survives for only four months

Joseph Conrad publishes his novel *Nostromo*, about a revolution in South America and a fatal horde of silver

France and Britain sign an Entente Cordiale, resolving several colonial disputes and laying the foundation for a new alliance

Helen Keller overcomes deafness and blindness to graduate *cum laude* at Radcliffe College in the USA

The German general Lothar von Trotha drives 8000 Herero people to slow death in the Kalahari desert

Henry James publishes his last completed novel, *The Golden Bowl*

An observatory with a 100-inch reflecting telescope is set up by George Ellery Hale on Mount Wilson in California

Constantine Cavafy prints fourteen of his poems in a pamphlet for private distribution

The US consul in Mexico, Edward Herbert Thompson, begins a very profitable excavation at the Mayan site of Chichén Itzá

Austrian psychologist Sigmund Freud publishes *The Psychopathology of Everyday Life*

Hughie Cannon writes the music and words for the song originally titled "He Done Me Wrong" in the US musical *Frankie and Johnny*

British troops under Francis Younghusband enter Tibet's holy city of Lhasa

The publisher Walter Blackie moves into Hill House at Helensburgh, designed for him by Charles Rennie Mackintosh

J.M. Barrie's play for children *Peter Pan, or the Boy Who Wouldn't Grow Up* has its premiere in London

Alban Berg and Anton Webern study composition with Arnold Schoenberg in Vienna

1905

Alexander Scriabin completes his Third Symphony, *The Divine Poem*, which is given its first performance in Paris in 1905

US architect Louis Sullivan completes the Schlesinger & Meyer Store (later known as the Carson, Pirie & Scott Store) in Chicago

Theodore Roosevelt wins the US presidential election in his own right

US inventor King C. Gillette receives a patent for a disposable safety razor

Under the pseudonym Saki, H.H. Munro publishes *Reginald*, his first volume of short stories

Australian soprano Nellie Melba makes the first of a great many recordings

US president Theodore Roosevelt announces the Roosevelt Corollary to the Monroe Doctrine, in response to crises in Latin America

Dublin's Abbey Theatre opens as a new home for the Irish National Theatre Society

Gwen John makes her home in Paris, where she becomes Rodin's model and mistress

Transvaal politician Louis Botha forms Het Volk ('The People'), a party committed to Afrikaner self-government

The American sculptor Jacob Epstein moves from New York to settle in London

Troops fire on a demonstration in St Petersburg, in the event which becomes known as Bloody Sunday

Industrial Workers of the World (with its members later known as Wobblies) is founded in Chicago as a radical union initiative

The Bloomsbury Group gathers for informal evenings at the family home of Virginia and Vanessa Stephens (later Virginia Woolf and Vanessa Bell)

Strikes and riots sweep across Russia in the wake of St Petersburg's Bloody Sunday

Albert Einstein explains the photoelectric effect as a flow of discrete particles (quanta) of electromagnetic radiation

Henry Wood sets 'Rule Britannia' in his *Fantasia on British Sea Songs*, providing a traditional favourite for the last night of the Proms

More than 360,000 Norwegians vote to end the union with Sweden, with only 184 against

The Japanese defeat a larger force of Russians at Mukden in the final land battle of the Russo-Japanese War

English engineer Herbert Austin sets up a factory to manufacture cars at Longbridge, south of Birmingham

Kaiser Wilhelm II visits Tangier in support of Moroccan independence, causing a diplomatic crisis with the colonial powers France and Britain

German biologists Fritz Schaudinn and Erich Hoffmann discover the micro-organism *Treponema pallidum* which causes syphilis

Two thirds of the Russian fleet is sunk after being ambushed by Japanese warships in the Tsushima Strait

The largest diamond yet known is found in a South African mine belonging to Thomas Cullinan

Oscar Wilde's *De Profundis*, a letter of recrimination written in Reading Gaol to Lord Alfred Douglas, is published posthumously

In his special theory of relativity Albert Einstein reconciles the apparent clash between relativity and electromagnetic theory

Henri Matisse completes his painting *Luxe, Calme et Volupté*

US photographers Alfred Stieglitz and Edward Steichen set up the Little Galleries of the Photo-Secession in New York

French psychologists Alfred Binet and Theodore Simon develop a scale by which to measure the 'mental age' of children

Ernst Ludwig Kirchner and other Dresden students form the Expressionist group Die Brücke

Pablo Picasso's palette becomes warmer as Blue evolves into Rose

David Belasco's play *Girl of the Golden West* has its premiere in New York, where it is seen two years later by Giacomo Puccini

Alberta and Saskatchewan join the Canadian confederation, completing the 'prairie provinces'

Karol Szymanowski and other Polish composers form a group that soon becomes known as Young Poland

The Ulster Unionist Party is founded in Belfast to oppose Home Rule

The Russian composer Alexander Scriabin becomes influenced by the theosophy of Madame Blavatsky

Edith Wharton publishes the novel that brings her fame and fortune, *The House of Mirth*

Henri Matisse, in the south of France, paints *The Open Window, Collioure*, the first of his many works on this theme

The first boat to be powered by a combustion engine, the 125-ton vessel *Venoga*, is launched on Lake Geneva

A complaint about maggoty meat on the Russian battleship *Potemkin* leads to thousands of deaths after troops fire on a demonstration

English physiologists William Bayliss and Ernest Starling coin the word 'hormone' for glandular secretions into the bloodstream

The Maji-Maji rising results in alarming outbreaks of violence in German East Africa

The first German submarine, or U-boat, is constructed in a programme to catch up with Britain and France in this area

H.G. Wells publishes *Kipps: the story of a simple soul*, a comic novel about a bumbling draper's assistant

The German commander in east Africa uses famine as a means of ending the Maji-Maji rising

US philosopher George Santayana publishes the first of the five volumes of his *Life of Reason*

President Theodore Roosevelt mediates a peace treaty in Portsmouth, New Hampshire, between Russia and Japan

Hitler moves to Vienna, hoping to be a painter, but is twice rejected as a student by the Academy of Fine Arts

Thomas Dixon's popular novel *The Clansman* presents the Ku Klux Klan in heroic terms

Aristide Maillol has his first major success with a large sculpture at the Salon d'Automne in Paris

The Treaty of Portsmouth gives Japan control of Port Arthur and much of the Liaotung Peninsula

Britain's Automobile Association is founded, with patrol-men on bicycles to assist drivers

Claude Debussy completes the three symphonic sketches forming *La Mer*

Albert Einstein relates mass and energy in the equation $e = mc^2$

Matisse, Derain and others, exhibiting in Paris their shockingly colourful new works, are dubbed *fauves* ("wild beasts") by a critic

The first *soviet* ("council") of workers is set up in St Petersburg, introducing a word of great significance in Russian Communist history

The Dutch dancer Gertrud Zelle begins a career in Paris, using the stage name Mata Hari

Tsar Nicholas II reluctantly signs the October Manifesto, authorizing an elected *duma* or legislature

1906

Percival Lowell predicts the existence of an unknown planet, almost exactly where Pluto is discovered 25 years later

Gustav Mahler's cycle of five songs, *Kindertotenlieder*, is its first performance in Vienna

The monk Grigory Rasputin exercises a powerful influence over the Russian empress Alexandra

Bernard Shaw has two new plays opening in London in the same year, *Major Barbara* and *Man and Superman*

The designer Edward Gordon Craig publishes a theatrical manifesto, *The Art of the Theatre*

Conservative prime minister Balfour resigns and Henry Campbell-Bannerman forms an interim Liberal government in Britain

Richard Strauss's *Salome*, based on Oscar Wilde's play, has wide success in spite of censorship difficulties

Franz Lehár's operetta *The Merry Widow* opens in Vienna at the start of an immensely successful run

Sir Percy Blakeney rescues aristocrats from the guillotine in Baroness Orczy's *The Scarlet Pimpernel*

17-year-old Charlie Chaplin joins the Fred Karno company, touring slapstick comedy

Henry Campbell-Bannerman leads the Liberals to a massive election victory in the UK on a promised programme of reform

Britain's Labour Party achieves its first electoral success, winning twenty-nine seats at Westminster

Britain launches HMS *Dreadnought*, the first of a massive new class of battleship

The first part of the Post Office Savings Bank in Vienna is completed, to the designs of Otto Wagner

Upton Sinclair publishes *The Jungle*, a hard-hitting novel about the Chicago meat-packing industry

More than 1200 French miners die in an underground explosion in the district of Calais

Cardiff's new Civic Centre is launched with the completion of the City Hall and Law Courts, designed by Lanchester, Stewart and Rickards

English biologist William Bateson uses the word 'genetics' to describe the phenomenon of heredity and variation

An international conference at Algeciras effectively gives France informal control of Morocco

The Grain Growers' Grain Company is established, soon becoming an important element in Canada's grain market

Frederick Soddy observes his first examples of chemically identical elements with differing atomic weights, to which he later gives the name isotopes

Fire destroys much of San Francisco following the most violent earthquake in the city's history

The Liberals win a majority in election for Russia's new *duma* and press ahead with proposals for land reform

Antoni Gaudí completes his radical rebuilding of the Casa Batlló in Barcelona

Istanbul cedes the Sinai Peninsula to British-controlled Egypt

Tsar Nicholas II issues a Fundamental Law emphasizing his own autocratic power

In Charles Ives' composition *The Unanswered Question* the trumpet repeatedly asks 'the perennial question of existence'

German immunologist August von Wasserman develops a diagnostic test to reveal the presence of the syphilis spirochaete in the blood

Charles Pathé opens the first purpose-built luxury cinema, the Omnia-Pathé, in Paris

The first volume of the inexpensive Everyman's Library is issued by Joseph Dent, a London publisher

The Naturalization Act provides definitive requirements for naturalization as a US citizen

E. Nesbit publishes *The Railway Children*, the most successful of her books featuring the Bastable family

The Simplon rail tunnel, the longest in the world (20 km), is opened between Switzerland and Italy

In direct response to Britain's new *Dreadnought*, Germany increases the production of battleships

Tsar Nicholas II appoints as prime minister the reformist aristocrat Pyotr Stolypin

The first Grand Prix of motor-racing is held near Le Mans over a 64-mile course

Pablo Picasso's portrait of Gertrude Stein prefigures cubism in its mask-like treatment of her face

The Pure Food and Drug Act, a landmark initiative in consumer protection, becomes law in the US

Alfred Dreyfus is reinstated in the army after the French supreme court overturns his conviction for treason

Belgian physiologists Jules Bordet and Octave Gengou identify *Bacillus pertussis*, the bacterium causing whooping cough

Tsar Nicholas II summarily dismisses Russia's new duma when it has been sitting for only three months

Alfred Dreyfus is awarded the Légion d'Honneur ten days after his conviction has been annulled

Humorous Phases of Funny Faces, created by New Yorker J. Stuart Blackton, introduces the concept of the animated cartoon

The Cunard company launches the *Lusitania* on the Clyde as a sister ship to the *Mauretania*

The Great Valparaíso Earthquake damages much of central Chile and is felt from Peru to Buenos Aires

Frank Lloyd Wright builds a Unity Temple for the Unitarians in Oak Park, now a suburb of Chicago

A large retrospective exhibition in Paris gives Paul Gauguin a growing posthumous reputation

Mahatma Gandhi, confronted by racial discrimination in South Africa, launches a programme of passive resistance (*satyagraha*)

Sergei Diaghilev mounts a major exhibition of Russian art at the Petit Palais in Paris.

A paediatrician in Vienna, Clemens von Pirquet, describes a condition for which he coins the term 'allergy'

German physicist Walther Nernst establishes the Third Law of Thermodynamics, dealing with temperatures close to absolute zero

Ethel Smyth's most successful opera, *The Wreckers*, is premiered in Leipzig

6-year-old Fred Astaire and his sister Adele give their first professional performance, in the pier theatre in Keyport, New Jersey

Roald Amundsen and his crew are the first to achieve the Northwest Passage, in a journey lasting three years in a 70-ft fishing boat

The German neuropathologist Alois Alzheimer identifies physical symptoms in the brain of a dead woman who had presenile dementia

President Roosevelt wins a Nobel Peace Prize for his mediation between Russia and Japan

The Russian prime minister Pyotr Stolypin introduces land reform

The Story of the Kelly Gang, produced in Australia, is the first feature-length film, with a running time of nearly an hour

Transvaal is given the self-governing status promised in the treaty ending the Boer War

1907

Reginald Fessenden transmits on Christmas Eve, from Brant Rock, Massachusetts, the world's first radio broadcast

The All-India Muslim League is set up at a meeting of the Muhammadan Educational Conference in Dhaka

John Galsworthy publishes *The Man of Property*, the first of his novels chronicling the family of Soames Forsyte

US inventor Lee De Forest patents the Audion, a sensitive vacuum-tube radio receiver

J.M. Synge's *Playboy of the Western World* provokes violent reactions at its Dublin premiere

Frederick Delius's *Walk to the Paradise Garden* is added to his opera *A Village Romeo and Juliet* to cover a scene change during the Berlin premiere

Michel Fokine creates the ballet *Les Sylphides* (originally called *Chopiniana*) to music by Chopin

Maria Montessori establishes her first Casa dei Bambini in the deprived San Lorenzo district of Rome

Russian author Maxim Gorky completes his novel *Mat* ("The Mother"), written mainly during a visit to the USA

President Roosevelt sends marines to protect US property during political unrest in Honduras

Edmund Gosse publishes *Father and Son*, an account of his difficult relationship with his fundamentalist father, Philip Gosse

Dutch and British companies (Royal Dutch Oil, Shell Transport and Trading) merge to form Royal Dutch Shell Oil

An Entente signed between Britain and Russia follows on from the 1904 Entente Cordiale with France to establish a new Triple Entente

US philosopher William James publishes *Pragmatism: a New Name for Old Ways of Thinking*

Charles Stewart Rolls and Henry Royce build their most famous car, the Silver Ghost, in the factory they have set up in Derby

Russian impresario Sergei Diaghilev presents five concerts of Russian music in Paris

Gertrude Stein meets Alice B. Toklas, who becomes her secretary and lifelong companion

A separatist party in Spain, Solidaridad Catalana, makes electoral gains in Catalonia

Pablo Picasso's *Les Femmes d'Alger*, a violent transition into cubism, is a turning point in western art

Henkel & Cie launches in Düsseldorf the first domestic washing powder, Persil

Austrian scientist Clemens von Pirquet discovers a diagnostic test to identify tuberculosis in a patient

James Joyce completes the 15 short stories eventually published in 1914 as *Dubliners*

A fossilized human jaw, probably at least 500,000 years old, is found near Heidelberg in Germany

Collapse of trust companies causes panic and financial crisis in USA

The world's first custom-built motor-racing track opens at Brooklands, near Weybridge in Surrey

The Transvaal government presents to Edward VII the Cullinan diamond, now part of the British crown jewels

The Deutscher Werkbund is founded in Munich as an association of architects, designers and industrialists

Frederick Delius completes *Brigg Fair*, an 'English Rhapsody' for orchestra, first performed in Liverpool in 1908

Samuel Simon, working in Manchester, takes out a patent for the use of silk to support a stencil

The first International Horse Show takes place in London's Olympia stadium

The Harvester Judgement establishes a minimum wage in Australia

Swedish playwright August Strindberg publishes *The Ghost Sonata*, which has its first performance in Stockholm the following year

New Zealand becomes independent as a self-governing dominion

The British liner *Lusitania* sets a new record for the Atlantic crossing, on the first of four such occasions

Harry Lauder has a hit in the USA with his recording of *I Love a Lassie*

US cartoonist Bud Fisher creates Mutt and Jeff for the *San Francisco Chronicle*, in the world's first daily comic strip

A Midwest region, including what remains of the reserved Indian Territory, is included in Oklahoma when it joins the Union as the 46th state

20-year-old Le Corbusier builds his first house at La Chaux-de-Fonds, in his native Switzerland

President Roosevelt sends a fleet of warships on a goodwill tour of the world that also demonstrates US power

Anna Pavlova dances *The Dying Swan*, choreographed for her by Michel Fokine to music by Saint-Saëns

c. 1908

Robert Baden-Powell publishes *Scouting for Boys*, the success of which leads to the establishment of the Scouts

Jack London's novel *Iron Heel* foresees a future repressive capitalist regime in the USA

Rat, Mole and Toad, in Kenneth Grahame's *The Wind in the Willows*, appeal to a wide readership

The king of Portugal, Carlos I, and his heir, Luis Filipe, are shot as they ride in an open carriage in Lisbon

Anatole France casts a satirical eye on human society in his novel *L'île des pingouins* ("Penguin Island")

Jack Norworth and Albert von Tilzer write *Take Me Out to the Ball Game*, which becomes one of the most popular songs in the USA

The FBI (Federal Bureau of Investigation) is set up in Washington

The Young Turks of Salonika organize a successful uprising against the autocracy of the Ottoman sultan

Ezra Pound's first book of poems, *A Lume Spento*, is published in Italy

UK prime minister Henry Campbell-Bannerman resigns because of ill health and is followed as Liberal leader and prime minister by Herbert Asquith

David Lloyd George becomes chancellor of the exchequer in Asquith's new cabinet

The Polyscope Film Company releases the first horror movie, *Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*, filmed from a popular stage production

The Burmah Oil Company, developing a concession granted in 1901 to William Knox D'Arcy, discovers oil in Iran

Austria annexes Bosnia-Herzegovina, in response to the policy of the Young Turks in Istanbul

Sergei Diaghilev presents Fyodor Chaliapin in *Boris Godunov* at the Paris Opera

The Liberal government in Britain introduces an old-age pension, albeit only five shillings a week.

Ernest Shackleton, leading an expedition to the Antarctic, locates the south magnetic pole

Georges Braque's *Houses at L'Estaque* introduces analytic Cubism

Claude Debussy completes *Children's Corner*, pieces for piano which include 'Golliwog's Cake Walk'

International outrage at Congo atrocities forces Belgium to annexe King Leopold's private colony

German physicist Hans Geiger, working in England with Rutherford, develops an instrument that can detect and count alpha particles

Augusto Leguía begins a long spell as the strong man of Peruvian politics

Jack Norworth and Nora Bayes write "Shine on, Harvest Moon" for *The Follies of 1908*

Maurice Maeterlinck's *The Blue Bird* is performed at the Moscow Art Theatre in a production by Stanislavsky

Bronislava Nijinska joins her brother Vaslav in the Maryinsky company in St Petersburg

After first being discussed at the Berlin Radiotelegraphic Conference in 1906, SOS is formally ratified as the international distress signal

Swiss chemist Jacques Brandenberger patents cellophane, a flexible transparent film made from cellulose

Parliament in Australia chooses Canberra as the site of the nation's new capital

Coffee replaces sugar as Brazil's main crop, accounting for more than 50% of exports in 1908

Lucy Maud Montgomery's first novel, *Anne of Green Gables*, brings her instant fame and fortune

George McJunkin, near Folsom in New Mexico, sees the bones of an extinct giant bison, partially exposed after a flash flood, with an ancient spear point embedded in the skeleton

Modernist architect Adolf Loos attacks architectural ornament in *Ornament and Crime*

Arnold Schoenberg abandons tonality in his String Quartet No. 2

Alexander Scriabin's orchestral work, *Poem of Ecstasy*, has its first performance in New York

The first Model T Ford rolls off the production line at the Piquette Avenue Plant in Detroit

Prince Ferdinand of Bulgaria declares his country's independence from Ottoman rule and calls himself Tsar Ferdinand I

The last Manchu emperor, Puyi, is placed on the throne at the age of two on the death of his uncle, the Guanxu emperor

The Empress Dowager Cixi dies the day after selecting the infant Puyi for the Chinese throne

Gideons International place their first bible in a hotel bedroom, in Montana, USA

Europe's worst earthquake, centred on the Strait of Messina, kills up to 200,000 people in Sicily and southern Italy.

William Howard Taft, the Republican candidate, is elected to follow Roosevelt as president

The French critic Louis Vauxcelles describes Braque's latest landscapes as being composed of cubes, resulting in the term cubism

US boxer Jack Johnson becomes the first black heavyweight champion when he knocks out Tommy Burns in Australia

The Welsh poet W.H. Davies has a success with *The Autobiography of a Super-Tramp*, his account of life on the road and in dosshouses

1909

Bernard Leach moves to Japan to study oriental traditions in the graphic arts

The opera *Elektra*, the first collaboration between Richard Strauss and Hugo von Hofmannsthal, has its premiere in Dresden

Michel Fokine becomes the choreographer for the ballet company that Sergei Diaghilev is taking to Paris

Ralph Vaughan Williams sets poems by Housman in *On Wenlock Edge*

Italian educational pioneer Maria Montessori publishes *The Montessori Method*

Rugby Union acquires new headquarters and a state-of-the-art stadium at Twickenham

Alexandre Benois becomes the first artistic director of Diaghilev's Ballets Russes

The National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) is founded in response to two lynchings in Illinois

Arnold Schoenberg composes his opera for a single voice, *Erwartung*, which remains unperformed until 1924 in Prague

Leo Baekeland announces his discovery of Bakelite, calling it 'the material of a thousand uses'

National delegates from the four provincial parliaments draw up a draft constitution for a South African union

French biologist Charles Nicolle discovers that epidemic typhus is transmitted by the body louse

Mary Pickford begins her film career at sixteen, when she is hired by D.W. Griffith

André Gide publishes *La Porte étroite* ('Strait is the Gate')

Isaac Albéniz completes his series of 12 piano pieces published under the title *Iberia*.

René Lalique, originally known for his jewellery, sets up his own glass-making factory at Combes-la-Ville

15-year-old Andrés Segovia gives his first public performance as a guitarist in Granada

Vaughan Williams first symphony, which he names *A Sea Symphony*, is first performed at the Leeds Festival

Diaghilev presents the first season of Ballets Russes in Paris, with Pavlova and Nijinsky in the company

Fokine's 1907 ballet *Chopiniana* is revised and given a new name, *Les Sylphides*

Jack London publishes his most autobiographical novel, *Martin Eden*

The heroine of H.G. Wells' novel *Ann Veronica* is a determined example of the New Woman

US entrepreneur Gordon Selfridge opens the first British custom-built department store on London's Oxford Street

Sea captain Joseph-Elzéar Bernier unveils a plaque in the Arctic Archipelago, declaring that all the islands belong to Canada

Mahatma Gandhi, on a visit to India, publishes a pamphlet entitled *Hind Swaraj* ("Indian Home Rule")

President Taft builds the first Oval Office, in the new west wing of the White House

US physicist Robert A. Millikan devises an oil drop experiment that determines the charge of an electron

Louis Blériot is the first to fly across the English Channel, winning the £1000 prize offered by the *Daily Mail*

Mineral discoveries on the border of Northern Rhodesia and the Belgian Congo give the first hint of the riches of the Copper Belt

The Selig Polyscope Company sets up the first film studio in the Los Angeles region, at Edendale

Sergei Rachmaninov premieres his Third Piano Concerto during his tour of the USA as a pianist

Karl Landsteiner classifies the main human blood groups as A, B, AB and O

Thomas Beecham uses his personal fortune from Beecham's Pills to found his first orchestra, the Beecham Symphony Orchestra

Set-designer Leon Bakst begins a long association with Diaghilev's Ballets Russes

President Taft sends marines to Nicaragua after the government there executes two US citizens

In response to fears of German espionage a Secret Service Bureau, later to be divided into MI5 and MI6, is set up in Britain

The Conservative majority in the House of Lords rejects Lloyd George's reforming budget, giving the Liberals the chance to call an election on an emotive issue

Rimsky-Korsakov's opera *The Golden Cockerel* has its premiere in Moscow

Joshua Slocum, the most famous sailor of the day, vanishes on another lone voyage

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African Americans in Burlington, Vermont, 1880–1900

The history of black people in Burlington during the late nineteenth century developed within the wider context of other local ethnic groups, but also should be understood on its own terms. At the same time, Afro-Burlingtonians shared many similarities with the experience of black people in other small New England cities such as Bangor.

By HARVEY AMANI WHITFIELD

Abial and Clara Anthony headed one of the more prominent and stable black families in late-nineteenth-century Burlington.¹ In 1880, Vermont native Abial Anthony's household consisted of five individuals. His wife, Clara, had migrated from South Carolina, and the couple had three children. It is unclear why Clara came to Burlington. Did she find out about this distant city through kinship and family networks or was she an adventurous spirit who wanted to travel north and by chance ended up in Burlington? In the Anthony household, Clara stayed at home, while the eldest child, eleven-year-old Nettie, attended school and Abial worked as a barber, one of the few avenues open to black males to improve their social standing in Burlington.² Ten years later, the family lived at 195 Elmwood Avenue and Abial Anthony no longer worked with African American barber

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George Williams, but had a shop at 102 Church Street.³ Two years later, he employed an African American barber named Jacob Bland.⁴ At the turn of the century, Abial owned his home at 195 Elmwood and continued to work as a barber on Church Street.⁵

The life of Abial Anthony demonstrates both the possibilities and limitations of primary source material for black history in Burlington. Although historians can trace the general contours of Abial and Clara's lives, we do not know whether they had a happy marriage, what they did for fun, their political inclinations, or if they enjoyed life in Burlington. However, what historians can glean from the historical records, fragmentary though they are, does allow us to recreate the lives of some African Americans in Burlington.⁶

This article explores the black community in Burlington during the late nineteenth century.⁷ It is divided into five sections, covering the census and city directories as sources for Afro-Burlingtonian history, the places of origin of local blacks in 1880 and 1900, occupational patterns, rates of persistence among Afro-Burlingtonians, and residential patterns.

Between 1865 and 1900, Burlington was transformed from a small town into the state's largest urban area. The city's growth resulted from the development of manufacturing industries and the timber trade. An important aspect of the city's development was the population growth of local ethnic groups such as the Irish, French Canadians, Jews, and Italians. These groups usually settled in ethnically segregated neighborhoods at first, developed various community institutions, gradually achieved some form of upward social and economic mobility, and eventually assimilated into the wider Burlington community.⁸

In some ways, the history of black people in Burlington followed a similar pattern, but it also differed in noteworthy ways. During the late nineteenth century, as the various populations of Burlington's ethnic groups increased, so did the numbers of African Americans. Between 1870 and 1880 the African American population in Burlington increased from 77 individuals to approximately 115 (Table 1). The population remained at this level throughout the remainder of the century.⁹ Similar to other ethnic groups, Afro-Burlingtonians chose to live close to one another. In contrast to other ethnic groups, Afro-Burlingtonians did not develop a separate black church or any long-lasting social organizations. This is very significant because the hallmarks of African American communities in the post bellum United States were black churches and social organizations. It is extremely difficult to know why black people in Burlington did not have a black church when other New England cities at this time such as Newport, R.I., and Portsmouth, N.H., did. But the black community in Bangor, Maine, which had an African

TABLE 1 Total Population and Black Population in Burlington, 1830–1900¹⁰

<i>Year</i>	<i>Total Population</i>	<i>Burlington Black Population</i>
1830	3,526	53
1840	4,271	38
1850	7,585	62
1860	7,713	46
1870	13,596	77
1880	11,365	116 (115)
1890	14,590	115
1900	18,640	115 (116)

American populace similar in size to Burlington, did not maintain a separate black church either. Perhaps, as in Bangor, black people in Burlington came from a variety of religious backgrounds and found their needs served in the existing churches.¹¹ Local blacks might have had numerous informal social institutions including religious services in private homes.

During the late 1870s, Afro-Burlingtonians maintained one “colored” organization. Lodge No. 8 was part of the Independent Order of Good Templars (IOGT) and lasted until the mid-1880s. However, the information about this organization and its status is unclear. Although initially listed as a “colored” lodge in the 1879–81 city directory, it did not appear in 1881–83, by 1884–85 the directory no longer identified it as an exclusively black organization, and after 1886–87 Lodge No. 8 disappeared from the directory altogether. Throughout all of these transitions during the 1880s, however the contact person was African American barber George Williams.¹² These tantalizing details raise significant questions. Had Lodge No. 8 become an integrated or biracial society during the early 1880s? If so, why? Did Lodge No. 8 represent a broader attempt by the Afro-Burlingtonian community to integrate into the social mainstream? Perhaps the failure of the directory to identify the lodge as “colored” simply resulted from the fact that everyone in the town knew the society was for African Americans. Whatever the case, during the 1870s and 1880s the Good Templars experienced a schism between those who wanted to maintain a race-neutral policy of admission and those who favored segregating lodges by race. David Fahey’s *Temperance and Racism* demonstrates that African American Templars were not united over the issue of integrated or separate lodges. Some believed that separate lodges were offensive and only mollified the opinions of

Southern whites, while others wanted the opportunity to build separate societies that might uplift the race.¹³ It is possible that Lodge No. 8 was influenced by this debate among the IOGT and refused to bow to segregationist impulses, instead opting for an integrated organization. Aside from the possibilities of Lodge No. 8, no other African American social or political organizations have yet turned up in the historical record. The lack of visible social institutions might reflect conscious attempts to integrate Burlington's social networks, but it could also simply show that the small size of the local black population made it difficult to develop formal organizations such as the French Canadian St. John Baptist Society or the Hebrew Charitable Association.

Unlike some ethnic groups in Burlington discussed in Elin Anderson's 1937 study *We Americans*, the vast majority of black people did not achieve upward social or economic mobility.¹⁴ Thus, the history of black people in Burlington during the late nineteenth century developed within the wider context of other local ethnic groups, but also should be understood on its own terms. At the same time, Afro-Burlingtonians shared many similarities with the experience of black people in other small New England cities such as Bangor.

In her fine study, *Black Bangor*, Maureen Elgersman Lee explores the contours of the African American community by asking about place of birth, occupations, residential patterns, identity, and institutions. The present study of black people in Burlington also examines some of these important questions, especially for the years after 1880.¹⁵ Preliminary answers to these questions can be explored through a close examination of the United States censuses and Burlington city directories.

CENSUS AND CITY DIRECTORIES AS HISTORICAL SOURCES

One consequence of the absence of an independent African American church or lasting community organizations is that few resources that would provide insights into the community's attitudes or actions such as church records or minutes of organizations are extant. Thus, as the work of historian Elise Guyette demonstrates, the United States censuses are important resources for Afro-Vermont history.¹⁶ The censuses of the late nineteenth century are both helpful and problematic. They provide important information such as racial designation, age, family structure, occupation, school attendance, birthplace, and parents' place of birth, literacy, and home ownership. But they also have several inherent problems such as undercounting, missing individuals, counting some people more than once, and the absence of information in specific categories such as occupation or property ownership.¹⁷

These general problems are compounded by more specific problems.

For example, the “census of 1870 is agreed by most researchers to be one of the most inaccurate of all of the American censuses.”¹⁸ This census greatly undercounted African Americans throughout the country. Despite these obstacles, Guyette has compiled a list of Afro-Vermonters from 1790 to 1870. This article builds on her research through a study of the 1880 and 1900 censuses, which are much more reliable than the 1870 census. Those interested in using the census for black history in the late nineteenth century are also hampered by the loss of the 1890 census, which was destroyed by a fire in Washington, D.C. Thus, in trying to understand rates of persistence, particularly for the two most reliable censuses (1880 and 1900), historians are faced with a twenty-year gap.

In the case of Burlington, city directories partially compensate for this gap. Beginning in the mid-1880s, the directories designated some individuals as “colored.” They also list residence and sometimes occupation. As there was population movement in and out of Burlington between census years the city directories offer glimpses of individual African Americans who were not enumerated in the census. This is particularly helpful for obtaining names of people who might have arrived after the 1880 census but left before the 1900 census. One example is Walter Stewart, who resided in the black neighborhood at 54 North Champlain Street and worked as a teamster in 1889/90.¹⁹ He is not listed in either the 1880 or 1900 census and seems to have left Burlington in 1891.

The city directories, however, are not without problems. Some Afro-Burlingtonians are not listed as colored. For example, William Armstead, a mulatto barber from Virginia, was identified as colored in the 1886/87 city directory, but not listed as African American in the 1889/90 directory.²⁰ Used in combination, the census and local city directories are important sources for black history, but researchers must be aware of their inadequacies and attempt to work around the fragmentary nature of the information they provide.

PLACES OF ORIGIN

A diverse community of African American migrants made Burlington their home during the late nineteenth century. These settlers came as single men and women, nuclear families, and extended kinship networks, bringing various skills and work experiences with them. One example is John Moore, who was born in Maryland in 1824. He migrated to New York and married a native of that state named Mary. In 1862, Mary gave birth to their eldest daughter. Eventually, the family moved to Burlington, where John worked as a cook. By 1880 the Moore household included two more children and a pair of granddaughters who had

all been born in Vermont.²¹ Mary Hazard, in contrast, moved to Vermont alone. She migrated from New York and worked as a servant in Burlington.²² In 1880 Priscilla Johnson worked as a dressmaker. A single mother of two young children, she had left Massachusetts to settle in Burlington.²³ Originally from Tennessee, Henry Fitch married Virginia native Anna Fitch and both settled in Burlington.²⁴ In 1900 Frank States worked as a foreman in railroad construction after migrating to Burlington from Canada. During the same year, Laura Johnson, the niece of local barber Abial Anthony, left her native New York and migrated to Vermont to attend school.²⁵ Black migrants to Burlington, especially those from the southern United States and New York, were part of larger population shifts that partially defined the African American experience during the late nineteenth century.

One of the most definitive aspects of late-nineteenth-century North American history was the migration of various groups of people to and throughout the United States. European immigrants came to the U.S. after the Civil War in search of jobs that had become plentiful as a result of the rapidly industrializing economy. At the same time, as Canada's economy struggled, many of its citizens also sought work in the United States.²⁶ Many French Canadians found jobs in Burlington as the city industrialized.²⁷

African Americans also hoped to find new lives outside of the post-Reconstruction South. Between 1880 and 1900, Southern blacks faced the destruction of their political rights, increased lynching, limited educational opportunities, and hostile race relations. The struggles associated with sharecropping or tenant farming made life in the Southern states difficult at best. As a result, many black Southerners looked for opportunities elsewhere. Tens of thousands of African Americans left the region for an uncertain future in Kansas; others went to urban areas and a few went to Africa.²⁸ Northern cities held out opportunities that hardly existed in the rural South. Large and small cities offered industrial work, better schools, decent wages, and exciting urban living in comparison to the boredom of rural life. The South suffered a net out-migration of 60,000 African Americans during the 1870s; this number jumped dramatically to 168,000 by the 1890s.²⁹ As a result of this out-migration, cities such as New York and Philadelphia experienced increases in their African American populations. Bangor, Boston, and Burlington were not major destinations of this migration, but as Lee notes, African Americans did resettle in New England.³⁰

The migration of African Americans to Bangor, Boston, and Burlington suggests two questions: How did migrants know about these distant cities and why, especially in the case of Bangor and Burlington,

did they choose to settle in northern New England as opposed to Philadelphia or New York?

Black migration went beyond just a few major urban centers; it took place within a much wider context that constituted a “national network” of cities.³¹ Bangor, Boston, and Burlington were part of this national network, but not highly desirable destinations among African American migrants. Historian Elizabeth Hafkin Pleck notes that even Boston was not popular among black migrants from the South. By the late nineteenth century, “most black Virginians went to New York, Pennsylvania, or New Jersey, and not to Massachusetts.”³² But economic possibilities, she points out, resulted in some black Southerners seeking better opportunities in Boston.³³

Burlington also offered several attractions to potential migrants from New York and the southeastern United States. First, as historian David Quigley demonstrates, extreme racial tensions in New York during the 1860s resulted in intensifying class differences that placed black Americans, especially those in poverty, at the lowest rung of society.³⁴ Moreover, increasing numbers of black migrants to New York City and the influx of European immigrants made competition for jobs fierce. Burlington, in contrast, had less overt racism, no legal discrimination, no racial restrictions on suffrage, and the possibility of better schools.³⁵

Black people in New York or points further south probably found out about Burlington from family, kinship networks, and friends. Historians have emphasized the importance of family and friends in helping to encourage and organize black migration to various cities.³⁶ Perhaps the most important aspect of black family networking and organization was chain migration, a phenomenon common as well among white ethnic groups in the United States. According to John and Leatrice MacDonald, through chain migration “migrants learn of opportunities, are provided with transportation, and have initial accommodation and employment arranged by means of primary social relationships with previous migrants.”³⁷ These relationships were influential in the migration of black people to Boston. Pleck states that the decision of African Americans to migrate to that city “formed part of the history of the black family, insofar as family and friends, rather than recruiting agents, made it possible.” These family networks linked “the Tidewater to Wheeler Street,” and in the case of Afro-Burlington linked Intervale Avenue, North Champlain Street, and Elmwood Avenue with New York and Virginia.³⁸ Several black households in Burlington resulted from kinship networks. For example, in 1880, native New Yorker Eliza Anthony lived with her daughter and son-in-law. Her daughter, Nettie had moved to Burlington and married Vermont native George Williams.³⁹

Twenty years later, the Williams household also included two elderly women from New York, one an aunt of George Williams and the other his mother-in-law.⁴⁰ Afro-Burlingtonians with relatives who stayed behind in Virginia or New York very likely maintained connections with them and were probably responsible for chain migration to Vermont.

The migration of southern- and northern-born blacks to Burlington connected this small community with the more substantial African American populations in Virginia and New York. In 1880, slightly more than half of Burlington's black population had been born inside the state.⁴¹ The majority of those from outside of Vermont came from New York and Virginia. Other migrants came from Massachusetts, Maryland, South Carolina, Tennessee, Connecticut, New Jersey, Louisiana, and Canada.⁴² By 1900, Vermont-born black Burlingtonians had increased to more than two-thirds of the African American population. At the same time that the percentage of native born Vermonters increased among Burlington's black population, Vermont ranked last among New England states at the turn of the century in its ability to retain its native-born black population. Nearly 63 percent of Afro-Vermonters lived outside of the state in 1900.⁴³ But these migrants were part of a larger trend of general out-migration from Vermont during the late nineteenth century.⁴⁴ The black population in Burlington was highly mobile and relatively diverse. African Americans who had experienced slavery lived in the same Burlington neighborhoods and walked the same streets as free-born black people from Massachusetts; African Canadians also mixed with black people from the Caribbean.⁴⁵

The migration of African Americans to Burlington can be better understood by comparing it to Bangor and Boston, which provides a broader picture of black migration to New England. Pleck has identified several trends among black migrants to Boston between 1870 and 1900 that also held true for African Americans who settled in Burlington. For example, many migrants to Boston were from Virginia and a high percentage of them were mulattoes.⁴⁶ Black Virginians also composed the vast majority of Southern migrants to Burlington and most of them were mulattoes.⁴⁷ The large number of mulatto migrants to Burlington was part of a broader trend of black migration into northern cities. Both Philadelphia and Boston attracted these lighter-skinned African Americans and this is significant because, as Pleck notes, "[u]nlike most black southerners, those in Boston were disproportionately urban, mulatto, literate, and from the Upper South." The same could be said for black Southerners in Burlington. These traits of black migrants "were also the attributes of the South's free blacks" and thus some blacks in Burlington and Boston may have been free even before the

conclusion of the Civil War. Also, it is not surprising that many of the skilled mulatto migrants from the South in Burlington brought specialized occupational knowledge to this city and obtained semiskilled and skilled jobs. In many Southern states mulattoes represented a separate class from African Americans and also enjoyed certain privileges that were not always extended to their darker brethren. Mulattoes were conscious of this difference and sometimes tried to find marriage partners of the same skin tone. In some ways, as historian James Oliver Horton points out, whites favored mulattoes and “sometimes” lighter African Americans separated themselves from darker African Americans. How these differences between darker and lighter African Americans played out in Burlington awaits a more sustained investigation than I can offer in this article.⁴⁸

These migrants from Virginia to Burlington brought various work experiences, and migrated both with and without family members. For example, William Watkins, a mulatto, came to Burlington and found work as a janitor. His wife Lizzie had been born in New York.⁴⁹ John Stewart, another mulatto born in Virginia, migrated to Burlington and worked as a laborer as of 1880. Charles Short left Virginia and eventually found employment as a hotel waiter in Burlington.⁵⁰ Perhaps the best-known black Virginian migrant in Burlington during the late 1870s was George Washington Henderson. Born in Virginia in 1850, Henderson migrated north with a Vermont soldier whom he had worked for as a servant during the Civil War. After finishing secondary school, he attended the University of Vermont and graduated first in his class in 1877. Henderson earned an M.A. at the University of Vermont and took a Bachelors of Divinity at Yale in 1883. Henderson dedicated the rest of his life to education and taught at several secondary schools and colleges across the country.⁵¹

Despite the similarities among black migrants to New England, there were some significant differences. First, the majority of northern-born black migrants to Bangor were from Massachusetts,⁵² and African Americans from Pennsylvania and New York were the two largest groups of black northerners in Boston (not including Massachusetts-born blacks who resided in Boston). In Burlington, Afro-New Yorkers made up the largest contingent and according to the census enumerators there was not one African American from Pennsylvania living in Burlington between 1880 and 1900.⁵³ Another significant difference between the African American populations in Burlington and Bangor and Boston was the presence of black people from Canada’s Maritime Provinces in the latter two cities. Lee notes that Canadians “comprised Black Bangor’s largest immigrant group.”⁵⁴ Also, Boston’s historic economic and social

connections along with its closeness by ship meant that some African Nova Scotians (and white Nova Scotians as well) sought employment in the bustling industrial market.⁵⁵ Burlington was close to Montreal, which did have a black community in the late nineteenth century, but Montreal had more industrial and other job opportunities than Halifax or any city in New Brunswick.

OCCUPATIONS

In many ways, the work patterns of African Americans in Bangor, Boston, and Burlington during the late nineteenth century had much in common with the struggles of free blacks in New England before the Civil War. In *Making a Living: The Work Experience of African-Americans in New England*, historians Robert Hall and Michael Harvey note that many blacks worked several different jobs to make ends meet.⁵⁶ The work that these African Americans found ranged from laboring in the dockyards to domestic service. Some black women worked outside of the home, took care of children, and performed other forms of household labor, as did women from other ethnic groups in Vermont.⁵⁷ Between 1790 and 1870, as Guyette notes, most Afro-Vermonters worked in menial employment and few achieved social mobility.⁵⁸ Although Guyette's work is about black people throughout Vermont, her conclusions about menial employment and limited economic mobility also hold true for black people in late-nineteenth-century Burlington.

After the Civil War, new opportunities for industrial jobs arose, but many black New Englanders were stuck in unskilled and sporadic employment that could be backbreaking and brutal. In Bangor, some black workers were "trapped in a makeshift economy that required them to piece together unskilled or service labor at different phases of their lives or from season to season."⁵⁹ In Boston, African Americans faced a discriminatory job market that "involved crowding black workers, especially newcomers, into low-wage labor."⁶⁰ More than 75 percent of black men in major northeastern cities including Boston, New York, and Philadelphia were employed in menial labor at the turn of the century.⁶¹ This section explores the employment patterns of Afro-Burlingtonians in 1880, skilled employment, the work of women, and occupational changes by 1900.⁶²

Despite Burlington's economic expansion, few African Americans found employment in the city's burgeoning industries and in most cases were relegated to unskilled jobs. Moreover, there were no black doctors, lawyers, ministers or teachers.⁶³ Still, Afro-Burlingtonians worked in various occupations ranging from barbers to domestic servants. The complexity of black Burlington's employment patterns mirrored broader

trends among the city's white population. As historian T.D. Seymour Bassett notes, "Burlingtonians were heterogeneous in occupations."⁶⁴ The 1880 and 1900 United States censuses offer a general profile for understanding the various tasks that black people in Burlington undertook to feed their families.

In 1880, nearly three-quarters of African American men and women in Burlington worked in menial or unskilled occupations. These jobs included cook, janitor, washerwoman, bakery worker, hotel waiter, and porter.⁶⁵ The majority of unskilled workers were listed by census takers as laborers or servants of one type or another.⁶⁶ These nondescript terms could have included the plying of numerous tasks from working on roads to picking up garbage to shoveling snow, depending on what was available during a given season. This type of labor was not exclusive to African Americans, as some white working people also found different jobs depending on the season.⁶⁷ Overall, in 1880, 68 percent of black men in Burlington were employed in unskilled jobs.⁶⁸ In comparison to French-Canadian workers in Burlington in 1870, Afro-Burlingtonians fared a bit better. In her study of the French-Canadian community, Betsey Beattie notes that 71.5 percent of men were employed in semi/unskilled labor (if we include factory and farm labor the percentage would be over 75), while approximately 21 percent worked in skilled jobs.⁶⁹

Approximately one-third of Afro-Burlingtonian men held skilled positions in 1880. These occupations included carpenter, printer, barber, and shoemaker. Perhaps these men constituted Burlington's African American middle class. Most of the skilled black workers were mulattoes and the vast majority had obtained literacy. The majority of these men worked as barbers.⁷⁰ For example, in 1886–87, barber George Williams employed four black men including Abial Anthony, Jacob Bland, and William Davis, who were all listed as barbers in the 1880 census.⁷¹ Also, George Williams and William Armstead were both listed in the business section of the city directory in 1889/90.⁷² Four years later, Abial Anthony was listed in the business section.⁷³ For African Americans in Boston and Burlington, working as a barber was a middle-class occupation with a steady income and respectable clientele. The other skilled trades of Afro-Burlingtonians, such as shoemaking, also provided steady family income. As a result, most wives of skilled black male workers stayed at home.⁷⁴

The employment patterns of black women in Burlington matched their counterparts in Boston and show many similarities to black females in Bangor as well. One of the dominant forms of work for African American women in Bangor was domestic service, while others worked as washerwomen. The vast majority of Afro-Burlingtonian women in

1880 who worked outside the home labored as domestic servants or washerwomen. Examples include Maria Moore and Rebecca Fields (domestics) and Martha James and Hattie Wyatt (washerwomen). It is possible that some washerwomen in Burlington and Bangor ran their own businesses. The one black female skilled worker identified in the 1880 census was a dressmaker.⁷⁵ The trend of black women working in domestic service can be found among women from other ethnic groups in Vermont. For example, Irish women in Northfield who worked outside of the home also generally labored as domestic servants.⁷⁶

Although the vast majority of black women in Burlington did not formally work outside the home, it is possible that they participated in an informal economy, which could have included street vending, house-to-house sales of various items, or midwifery. One household consisted of three women, two fifty-year-old sisters and a daughter only nineteen, none of whom supposedly worked outside of the home.⁷⁷ But in order to survive, these women had to have some form of income. Whatever the case, the small number of women working outside of the home could have been the result of personal choice. The tendency of black women, especially married ones, to remain in the home was also similar to Irish women in Northfield. As historian Gene Sessions notes, “it was rare in Northfield for a married Irish woman to have a job of any kind away from her home, regardless of the family’s economic condition.”⁷⁸

It is difficult to know definitively why most black women stayed home, but it is possible to offer some tentative explanations. Perhaps having African American women remain at home was an attempt to claim respectable middle-class ideals. Alternatively, black woman may have found staying home and raising children more rewarding than facing a discriminatory job market.⁷⁹ There are many instances of women who chose not to work outside of the home in Burlington; the Kelley family presents one example. In 1880, the head of household, James Kelley, was a carpenter and, possibly due to his income, his wife Jane had been “keeping house.” But four out of the couple’s five sons, including the eleven year old, worked in various jobs. The census taker described the couple’s niece, a twenty-year-old woman, as doing “nothing.”⁸⁰ Stay-at-home African American women were also married to men who held unskilled jobs. For example, in 1880, twenty-one-year-old Henry Fitch worked as a laborer, while his wife stayed at home and took care of their young baby. Mary Moore stayed at home, and her husband worked as a cook. The couple’s household also included three children and two grandchildren who were either at school or stayed home. Alfred Neil worked as a laborer, and his income was enough to support his wife and two daughters who went to school.⁸¹

By 1900, the occupational structure of Afro-Burlingtonians had changed for the worse. The percentage of laborers increased and African Americans participated in new forms of menial employment including bootblack, coachman, and peddler. The number of black barbers in Burlington also decreased between 1880 and 1900. Overall, the proportion of skilled workers among Afro-Burlingtonians decreased to only 17 percent by the turn of the century.⁸² The increases in unskilled occupations among Afro-Burlingtonians are even more disquieting if we compare them with the Irish in Northfield. In 1900, only 25 percent of Irish men in this small town worked in “unskilled” occupations, which marked a substantial decrease from the 50 percent of Irish male workers employed in menial jobs twenty years earlier.⁸³ Yet, this difference between Afro-Burlingtonians and the Irish in Northfield mirrored patterns in Boston, where Stephan Thernstrom and Pleck note the differences in occupational mobility between African Americans and Irish Americans. There are several possible explanations for these disparities ranging from racial discrimination to the longevity of certain residents in Boston.⁸⁴

It is difficult to account for the increase in unskilled laboring jobs among Afro-Burlingtonians. Competition from new migrants may have pushed African Americans out of certain jobs or perhaps racial discrimination relegated local blacks to the most menial and sporadic forms of employment. Most historians agree that the nadir of race relations in the post bellum United States was around the turn of the century, and this might be reflected in the changes to black occupations in Burlington.

RATES OF PERSISTENCE

The issue of persistence is one of the most significant questions historians can ask about the black community in Burlington. Very few individuals who had lived in Burlington in 1880 remained in the city by the time of the 1900 census. But the trend of migration into and out of Burlington occurred among various groups, not just Afro-Burlingtonians. For example, Bassett states that “[n]early half of the almost five thousand [French Canadians in Burlington] in 1870 had left by 1880.”⁸⁵ It is important to acknowledge that census enumerators could have missed certain individuals, and some black residents of Burlington in 1880 could have died before the 1900 census.⁸⁶ Moreover, examining rates of persistence can be challenging primarily because of name changes. For example, George Williams’s wife is listed as Nettie in the 1880 census, while the enumerator listed her as Hattie in the 1900 census. It is clear that these two names are actually the same person because of age (30 in 1880 and 49 in 1900), place of birth, and parents’ place of birth (all New York). Another fascinating example is Eliza Anthony. Between 1880

and 1900, Eliza changed her surname to Mingo, possibly because of the death of her husband or due to another marriage, but this is unlikely because she was in her early sixties in 1880. The mother-in-law of George Williams, she lived in the Williams household in 1880 and 1900. Despite the name change, Eliza's age, place of birth, and parents' place of birth make it clear that Eliza Anthony and Eliza Mingo were the same person.⁸⁷

The data about black people abandoning Burlington and arriving between 1880 and 1900 is astonishing. Although the population of black Burlington remained approximately the same in 1880 and 1900 (about 115 people), only 18 individuals listed in the earlier census can be found in the 1900 census.⁸⁸ This section considers who stayed, who left, and why. Also, the city directories for 1889/90, 1895, and 1899 are examined to check rates of persistence over shorter time periods.

Several factors seem to have been important in determining who decided to stay in Burlington including nativity, occupational status, and family connections. The persisters represented about 16 percent of the black population who had been included in the 1880 census. These 18 individuals included eight men, six women, and four children (age 16 and under in 1880).⁸⁹ The majority were native Vermonters, but probably more indicative of those who stayed is occupational stability and sometimes economic mobility. For example, as discussed earlier, Abial Anthony and George Williams had both been successful barbers during the late nineteenth century. Williams remained in Burlington along with his wife, son, daughter, mother-in-law, and aunt; while in 1900 Anthony lived with his wife, one daughter, and a niece.⁹⁰ Another barber, Jacob Bland, also remained in Burlington. Two janitors from Virginia, William Watkins and Madison Paxton, also stayed in Burlington. John Jones, who had worked as a laborer in 1880, became a fireman by 1900. The rate of persistence among children was also very small. Only four children listed in the 1880 census remained in Burlington by 1900.⁹¹ These children, three females and one male, included the daughters of George Williams and Abial Anthony. At the turn of the century, Victoria Williams did not work outside of the home, while Grace Anthony found employment as a nurse. Gertrude Freeman, a niece of George Williams, was only sixteen years old in 1880. Before the turn of the century, she had married a man by the last name of Kelley and had two children. Unfortunately, her husband died and she moved into the home of her mother, Rachel, who had also stayed in Vermont in this decade and worked as a cook.⁹²

The black people who left Burlington represented a much larger group than those who stayed and it is difficult to draw many conclu-

sions from this group because it was so much larger. However, a few tentative points can be made. Nearly 84 percent of black people in Burlington in 1880 did not reside in the city by 1900.⁹³ Those who migrated to other places included men, women, children, native Vermonters, and non-natives. Not surprisingly, both single people and entire families left Burlington. Some children of parents who stayed in Burlington made a decision to leave. For example, one of Abial Anthony's children, Albert (age eight in 1880), was not listed in the 1900 census. Albert did remain in Burlington for a few years during the 1890s and worked as a carpet layer, but probably left before the turn of the century.⁹⁴ Also, the eight-year-old daughter of George Williams in 1880 did not reside in Burlington by 1900. Benjamin Paxton and Emma Watkins, the young children of Madison and William respectively, both had left Burlington by 1900. These children who left Burlington were native Vermonters, from economically stable families, but still seem to have left their city of birth and perhaps the state. In some cases, entire families left Burlington and some of these people had many children under sixteen as of 1880. It is unlikely that all the children died. In fact, they probably left Burlington to seek opportunities elsewhere. For example, James and Hattie Wyatt had three children under age sixteen in 1880. But by 1900 the Wyatt children were gone. John Wyatt, the son of James and Hattie, left Burlington in 1892 and migrated to New York. Catherine and Mary Neil, the daughters of two Virginian parents who had settled in Burlington, were both born in Vermont. During the 1880s, they attended school in Burlington, but by 1900 they no longer resided in the city. The majority of children of Afro-Burlingtonians in 1880 did not reside there by the turn of the century. Perhaps, despite being raised in Burlington, they did not want to stay because their opportunities for social and economic improvement seemed limited.⁹⁵

The Burlington city directories during the late nineteenth century occasionally recorded that certain individuals had left the city and also mentioned where they relocated. Although this information is fragmentary, it does offer a glimpse into the various places that Afro-Burlingtonians migrated. Some of this out-migration was local. For example, during the 1890s Annie Fitch moved to Essex Junction, while Louis Johnson "removed to St. Albans."⁹⁶ Others left Burlington for more distant locations. Charles Johnson went to Atlanta in 1898, and Alfred Davis moved to New York City one year later.⁹⁷ It is not always clear why these people left Burlington, but the personal story of James Wyatt seems to be one of frustration. In 1894, he had completed his secondary schooling and was enrolled as a student at the University of Vermont. But the following year he worked as a porter at 91 Church Street. In 1896,

the city directory did not list him as employed anywhere. In 1898, Wyatt left Burlington for New York City.⁹⁸

The high rate of desertion of Afro-Burlingtonians over the last twenty years of the nineteenth century must be understood in the context of the destroyed 1890 census. In an effort to remedy this and take a different snapshot of the community, I have compared the 1889/90 and 1895 city directories to track rates of persistence over a much shorter time period. It must be noted that the city directories were hardly comprehensive listings of black people in Burlington. Instead, they identified heads of household and sometimes others within a particular household. The 1889/90 directory identified 45 African Americans, while the 1895 city directory edition listed 50 individuals. The rates of persistence for this five-year period are much higher in comparison to the persistence of black people between the 1880 and 1900 censuses. Of the 45 people listed in 1889/90, 25 still lived in Burlington in 1895.⁹⁹ In other words, about 56 percent of blacks listed in the earlier city directory remained in Burlington five years later.

However, comparing the city directories for 1889/90 and 1899 produces another picture of persistence. The 1899 directory listed only thirty-two African Americans, a drop of thirteen individuals (29 percent) from the beginning of the decade. However because the total population remained stable during the 1890s, at around 115 according to the census returns, it is unlikely that this decrease registered in the city directories actually reflects any serious loss of black people. It is more likely that this decline was the result of the city directory simply missing or failing to record certain black families. Whatever the case, 20 African Americans (44 percent) in the 1889/90 city directory still resided in Burlington as of 1899.¹⁰⁰ The rates of persistence among African Americans in Burlington were higher in a ten-year period of city directories than in the twenty-year period inbetween the two most reliable censuses of the late nineteenth century. But the city directories did not include young children so it is impossible to assess the rate of persistence among children. Overall, the rate of persistence among African Americans in Burlington during the late nineteenth century was low. It is interesting to note that this figure was not much different from the rate of persistence among French Canadians in Burlington between 1870 and 1880. Both cases should be understood within a wider context of renewal in Burlington. Indeed, as Bassett points out, “[m]any people moved in and out while the Queen City flourished.”¹⁰¹ As the black population held at approximately 115 during the last twenty years of the nineteenth century, given the low rate of persistence, several new African Americans moved to Burlington. How newer arrivals interacted with older residents is a question for future researchers to consider.

RESIDENTIAL PATTERNS

During the late nineteenth century, despite significant changes to the black population because of migration, the residential patterns of African Americans remained relatively stable. Between 1886 and 1900, according to the city directories, the majority of the black community, not including servants of wealthy whites, lived in the city's North End, usually within a few doors or blocks of one another and alongside many French Canadians. Also some Afro-Burlingtonians lived in extended households. In 1886, Marion and Fred Davis boarded at 20 Intervale with Arthur Davis, while a few doors down, John Wyatt boarded at the residence of Harry [Henry?] Fitch. Other black people lived in the near vicinity at streets such as Elmwood, North, Lafountain, and Peru.¹⁰² Four years later, black people continued to live in the same neighborhood.

In 1890, Willard Kelley lived a few doors down from Abial Anthony.¹⁰³ Charity Freeman lived near Willard Kelley at 215 Elmwood Avenue.¹⁰⁴ Born in Vermont, Freeman had lived in New York and given birth to a daughter there in 1861 before returning to Vermont by 1880. In 1890, several African American families listed in the Burlington city directory lived on Elmwood Avenue, and others resided within close proximity. The majority of black people lived within a few blocks of one another at Intervale Avenue and North Champlain Street.¹⁰⁵ Ten years later, most African Americans in Burlington still resided at Elmwood and North Champlain, but only a few remained at Intervale.¹⁰⁶ This general pattern of residential continuity suggests that even if a large segment of the black population in Burlington was transitory, those who remained for more than a few years were able to carve out residential space that would be occupied by other African Americans after earlier black residents had left the city.

CONCLUSION

Historians can draw a few conclusions about African Americans in Burlington in the last two decades of the century. First, the population remained around 115 people. Second, the majority of Afro-Burlingtonians were native Vermonters, but a significant minority came from Virginia and New York. Third, the majority of black people in Burlington worked unskilled jobs and the percentage of those working in menial occupations increased during the late nineteenth century. Fourth, the rate of persistence among African Americans in Burlington was low. Entire families left the city between the 1880 and 1900 census. However, the rate of persistence for black people over shorter time periods, such as five or ten years, was higher, hovering around 40 or 50 percent. Fifth, despite the high rate of migration in and out of the black community in

Burlington, African Americans lived nearby one another in a compact and distinct neighborhood.

Although these conclusions are limited, it is possible to offer several more intriguing possibilities about the black experience during the late nineteenth century by asking questions. First, why did the Irish in Northfield achieve upward social and economic mobility, while the general trend among Afro-Burlingtonians seems to point to downward mobility? The downward mobility of the local black population suggests that racism limited job opportunities. Scholar Noel Ignatiev has written about how the Irish eventually became accepted as white Americans and this acceptance, in the case of Vermont, probably opened up opportunities for social mobility that were denied to Afro-Burlingtonians.¹⁰⁷

Given the possibility of racism limiting job opportunities, it is important to ask why Afro-Burlingtonians did not develop an African American church or any long-lasting exclusively black social organizations. Certainly, these institutions often arose elsewhere as buffers against racism and job discrimination. Several interpretations are possible depending on whether historians want to see Afro-Burlingtonian history in a negative or positive light. The experience of black people in Burlington may be seen as negative in several ways: patterns of out-migration and immigration, downward economic mobility, small degree of home ownership, and the lack of community institutions. Perhaps the absence of social institutions contributed to making the black experience in Burlington unstable. Alternatively, it is possible that population fluctuation impeded the formation of stable social institutions. In contrast, there were some positive aspects to Afro-Burlingtonian life between 1880 and 1900. The community did have some families who achieved economic mobility. A few individuals owned their homes or small businesses such as barber shops. The younger generation attended schools and achieved literacy. It is possible that the absence of the church and social organizations reflected a conscious attempt of Afro-Burlingtonians to eschew segregated institutions in favor of integration into the city's mainstream by attending predominantly white churches and schools.

This paper may ask more questions than it answers. But, to stimulate further research, historians need a base to work from to ponder more significant and complex questions. Why did Afro-Burlingtonians have a "colored" society during the late 1870s that was no longer "colored" by the mid-1880s? Did Afro-Burlingtonians pursue a conscious strategy of integration? How did light-skinned African Americans get along with their darker neighbors? Did white Burlingtonians treat lighter African Americans differently from darker-skinned ones? Given the high rate of migration in and out of Burlington, how did older and more perma-

nent residents interact with new arrivals? Was there tension in these relationships between older and newer residents or were both groups mutually supportive of one another? What was the relationship between black people and French Canadians? How much interracial marriage occurred in Burlington and what can this tell us about broader interactions between blacks and Irish or French Canadians? The answers to these questions may be difficult to discover, but the history of black people in an overwhelmingly white state is an area for inquiry that may tell us additional and perhaps different stories about the black experience in late-nineteenth-century America.

NOTES

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² 1880 United States Census, Population Schedules of the Tenth Census of the United States.

³ *Burlington City Directory, 1889–90*, 66.

⁴ *Burlington City Directory, 1892*, 83.

⁵ 1900 United States Census, Population Schedules of the Twelfth Census of the United States; *Burlington City Directory, 1900*, 70.

⁶ 1900 United States Census.

⁷ The historiography of Afro-Vermonters or subjects that partially focus on African Americans includes, but is not limited to: David Work, "The Buffalo Soldiers in Vermont, 1909–1913," *Vermont History* 73 (Winter/Spring 2005): 63–75; Kari J. Winter, *The Blind African Slave: Or Memoirs of Boyrereau Brinch, Nicknamed Jeffrey Brace* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 2004); John Saillant, *Black Puritan, Black Republican: The Life and Thought of Lemuel Haynes, 1753–1833* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003); Stephen M. Wrinn, *Civil Rights in the Whitest State: Vermont's Perceptions of Civil Rights, 1945–1968* (Lanham, Maryland: University Press of America, 1998); Elsie B. Smith, "William J. Anderson: Shoreham's Negro Legislator in the Vermont House of Representatives," *Vermont History* 44 (Fall 1976): 203–213; John M. Lovejoy, "Racism in Antebellum Vermont," *Vermont History* 69 (Winter 2001): 48–65; Alice McShane, ed., "In Their Own Words: Reading, Writing, and War, A Vermonter's Experience in the Port Royal Experiment, 1863–1871," *Vermont History* 67 (Summer/Fall 1999): 101–114; Arthur O. White, "Prince Saunders: An Instance of Social Mobility among Antebellum New England Blacks," *Journal of Negro History* 60 (October 1975): 526–535; Randolph A. Roth, "The First Radical Abolitionists: The Reverend James Milligan and the Reformed Presbyterians of Vermont," *New England Quarterly* 55 (December 1982): 540–563; John L. Myers, "The Beginnings of Anti-Slavery Agencies in Vermont, 1832–1836," *Vermont History* 36 (Summer 1968): 126–141 [please note this article has a different title in the table of contents]; Marshall M. True, "Slavery in Burlington?: An Historical Note," *Vermont History* 50 (Fall 1982): 227–231; J. Kevin Graffagnino, "Vermont Attitudes Toward Slavery: The Need For A Closer Look," *Vermont History* 45 (Winter 1977): 31–35.

⁸ T.D. Seymour Bassett, *The Growing Edge: Vermont Villages, 1840–1880* (Montpelier: Vermont Historical Society, 1992), 197–221; Michael Sherman, Gene Sessions, and P. Jeffrey Potash, *Freedom and Unity: A History of Vermont* (Barre: Vermont Historical Society, 2004), 290–292; Elin Anderson, *We Americans: A Study of Cleavage in an American City* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1937); Betsy Beattie, "Migrants and Millworkers: The French Canadian Population of Burlington and Colchester, 1860–1870," *Vermont History* 60 (Spring 1992): 95–117; Betsy Beattie, "Community-Building in Uncertain Times: The French Canadians of Burlington and Colchester, 1850–1860," *Vermont History* 57 (Spring 1989): 84–102.

⁹ Between 1860 and 1900, Afro-Vermonters never made up more than 0.3 percent of the total state population. In 1860, 709 African Americans lived in Vermont, but this number increased ten years

later to 924. In 1880, the black population reached its peak for the period with 1,057 individuals, but then decreased to only 826 in 1900. The percentage of southern-born blacks in Vermont remained above 10 percent during the period and was 22 and 23 percent in 1870 and 1900, respectively.

¹⁰Elise A. Guyette, "Black Lives and White Racism in Vermont, 1760–1870," (MA Thesis, University of Vermont, 1992), 152–156; Sherman, Sessions, and Potash, *Freedom and Unity*, 627–628; *Report on Population of the United States at the Eleventh Census* (Washington: Government Printing Office, 1895), 556; *Census Reports Volume I: Twelfth Census of the United States Taken In The Year 1900* (Washington: United States Census Office, 1901), 682; 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census. The numbers in parenthesis are the totals that I found in the census. For the 1880 and 1900 census of Burlington, I identified 115 and 116 African Americans respectively from the population schedules. The published reports list the figures of African Americans in 1880 and 1900 as 116 and 115 respectively. The numbers used in this paper for the percentage of blacks in Burlington or for work patterns should be understood as generally correct. Of course, no historian's work is beyond reproach and it is possible that another researcher might find more names.

¹¹Maureen Elgersman Lee, *Black Bangor: African Americans in a Maine Community, 1880–1950* (Durham: University of New Hampshire Press, 2005), 89–95.

¹²*Burlington City Directory, 1879–1881*. Lodge No. 8 was not listed in the 1881–1883 directory, but reappeared in the directories of the mid-1880s without being listed as colored.

¹³David Fahey, *Temperance and Racism: John Bull, Johnny Reb, and the Good Templars* (Lexington: University Press of Kentucky, 1996).

¹⁴Anderson, *We Americans*, 124–186, 202–257; on page 40, Anderson noted that the subjects of her study did not want to live near black people or the Chinese. Perhaps these attitudes partially explain black people's limited assimilation in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century.

¹⁵Lee, *Black Bangor*, xv. Other treatments of African American history during the late nineteenth century include, but are not limited to, the following: Rayford Logan, *The Betrayal of the Negro: From Rutherford B. Hayes to Woodrow Wilson* (1965; reprint, New York: Da Capo Press, 1997); Elizabeth Haffkin Pleck, *Black Migration and Poverty: Boston 1865–1900* (New York: Academic Press, 1979); Richard Paul Fuke, *Imperfect Equality: African Americans and the Confines of White Racial Attitudes in Post-Emancipation Maryland* (New York: Fordham University Press, 1999); Jane Dailey, *Before Jim Crow: The Politics of Race in Postemancipation Virginia* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2000); Jeffrey R. Kerr-Ritchie, *Freedpeople in the Tobacco South: Virginia, 1860–1900* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1999); Allison Dorsey, *To Build Our Lives Together: Community Formation in Black Atlanta, 1875–1906* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 2004); Michael J. Pfeifer, *Rough Justice: Lynching and American Society, 1874–1947* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2004); Heather Cox Richardson, *The Death of Reconstruction: Race, Labor, and Politics in the Post-Civil War North, 1865–1901* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2001); Gerald David Jaynes, *Branches Without Roots: Genesis of the Black Working Class in the American South, 1862–1882* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1986); Leon F. Litwack, *Trouble in Mind: Black Southerners in the Age of Jim Crow* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1998); Steven Hahn, *A Nation Under Our Feet: Black Political Struggles in the Rural South from Slavery to the Great Migration* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2003); W. Fitzhugh Brundage, *Lynching in the New South: Georgia and Virginia, 1880–1930* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1993); Louis R. Harlan, *Booker T. Washington: The Making of a Black Leader, 1856–1901* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1972); David Levering Lewis, *W.E.B. Du Bois: Biography of a Race, 1868–1919* (New York: Henry Holt, 1993); Patricia A. Schechter, *Ida B. Wells-Barnett and American Reform, 1880–1930* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2001); Howard N. Rabinowitz, *Race Relations in the Urban South, 1865–1890* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1978).

¹⁶Guyette, "Black Lives"; Elise A. Guyette, "The Working Lives of African Vermonters in Census and Literature, 1790–1870," *Vermont History* 61 (Spring 1993): 69–84.

¹⁷Census takers were not always circumspect or careful when enumerating African Americans. Elise Guyette discusses some of these problems, see "Black Lives," 60–61; on the limitations of the census in regard to the black population in nineteenth-century Boston, see Pleck, *Black Migration*, 214–218; Kris Inwood and Richard Reid, "Introduction: The Use of Census Manuscript Data for Historical Research," *Social History* 28 (November 1995): 301–311; on the problems of the census in North America see Bruce Curtis, *The Politics of Population: State Formation, Statistics, and the Census of Canada, 1840–1875* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2001).

¹⁸Richard Reid, "The 1870 United States Census and Black Underenumeration: A Test Case from North Carolina," *Social History* 28 (November 1995): 488. The period 1880 to 1900 is distinct in the history of black Burlington as the population jumped from 77 to 115 between 1870 and 1880. Also, some African Americans migrated to the city after 1870 including Madison Paxton and Jacob Bland, who left Rutland County for Burlington. These two men and parts of their families would remain in Burlington for the last twenty years of the nineteenth century. For Guyette's work, see Database of Center for Rural Studies, University of Vermont. Guyette's census work is available at

the website: www.historyharvest.org/census/africanamerican.html; Raeone Christensen Steuart, *Vermont 1870 Census Index* (Bountiful: Heritage Quest, 2000).

¹⁹ *Burlington City Directory, 1889–90*, 219.

²⁰ 1880 United States Census; see *Burlington City Directory, 1886–87*, 5; *Burlington City Directory, 1889–90*, 67.

²¹ 1880 United States Census.

²² *Ibid.*

²³ *Ibid.*

²⁴ *Ibid.* All of the couples discussed in this paper were black. Although some interracial marriages are evident in the 1880 and 1900 censuses, this difficult topic deserves more attention than this study can offer.

²⁵ 1900 United States Census.

²⁶ The Maritime Provinces suffered high out-migration. The classic study of this phenomenon is Alan A. Brookes, "Out-Migration from the Maritime Provinces, 1860–1900: Some Preliminary Considerations," *Acadiensis* 5 (Spring 1976): 26–55; the revisionist interpretation is Patricia A. Thornton, "The Problem of Out-Migration from Atlantic Canada, 1871–1921: A New Look," *Acadiensis* 15 (Autumn 1985): 3–34.

²⁷ Bassett, *The Growing Edge*, 175–196.

²⁸ Nell Irvin Painter, *Exodusters: Black Migration to Kansas after Reconstruction* (1976; reprint, New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1977); more generally on black migration and settlement in the west, see Quintard Taylor, *In Search of the Racial Frontier: African Americans in the American West, 1528–1990* (New York: Norton, 1998); on the Liberian Exodus of 1877, see Stephen W. Angell, *Bishop Henry McNeal Turner and African-American Religion in the South* (Knoxville: University of Tennessee Press, 1992).

²⁹ Lee, *Black Bangor*, 6.

³⁰ *Ibid.* 7.

³¹ Joe William Trotter, Jr., "Conclusion, Black Migration Studies: The Future," in Joe William Trotter, Jr., ed., *The Great Migration in Historical Perspective: New Dimensions of Race, Class, and Gender* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1991), 147.

³² Pleck, *Black Migration*, 58.

³³ *Ibid.* 55–61.

³⁴ David Quigley, *Second Founding: New York City, Reconstruction and the Making of American Democracy* (New York: Hill and Wang, 2004); David N. Gellman and David Quigley, eds., *Jim Crow New York: A Documentary History of Race and Citizenship, 1777–1877* (New York: New York University Press, 2003).

³⁵ 1900 United States Census.

³⁶ The importance of kinship networks is discussed in various geographic locations in Trotter, ed., *The Great Migration*; Pleck, *Black Migration*, 63–67.

³⁷ John S. MacDonald and Leatrice D. MacDonald, "Chain Migration, Ethnic Neighborhood Formation and Social Networks," *Milbank Memorial Fund* 42 (1964): 82, cited in Earl Lewis, "Expectations, Economic Opportunities, and Life in the Industrial Age: Black Migration to Norfolk, Virginia, 1910–1945," in *Great Migration*, 24.

³⁸ Pleck, *Black Migration*, 64.

³⁹ 1880 United States Census.

⁴⁰ 1900 United States Census.

⁴¹ 1880 United States Census. In 1880 the enumeration of the birthplaces of African Americans in Burlington were: 62 Vermont, 22 New York, 15 Virginia, 5 Massachusetts, 2 Maryland, 2 Canada, 1 South Carolina, 1 Connecticut, 1 Tennessee, 1 New Jersey, 1 United States, 1 Louisiana, 1 District of Columbia.

⁴² 1880 United States Census.

⁴³ U.S. Department of Commerce, Bureau of the Census, *Negro Population in the United States, 1790–1915* (New York: Arno Press, 1968), 71.

⁴⁴ Sherman, Sessions, and Potash, *Freedom and Unity*, 287–290.

⁴⁵ 1900 United States Census. Black hotel worker James Virgin was from Bermuda.

⁴⁶ Pleck, *Black Migration*, 52–53; Steven J. Hoffman, *Race, Class, and Power in the Building of Richmond, 1870–1920* (Jefferson, North Carolina: McFarland, 2004); Kerr-Ritchie, *Freedpeople in the Tobacco South*; Pleck, *Black Migration*, 57–60. The term mulatto was used to describe biracial Americans during the late nineteenth and twentieth centuries. Today, the term has been abandoned in favor of the word biracial or multiracial.

⁴⁷ The 1880 census for Burlington included a designation for mulattoes. In the 1880 census a substantial number of African Americans (from Vermont and other states) were listed as mulattoes; see 1880 United States Census.

⁴⁸ Pleck, *Black Migration*, 53; on the advantages of mulattoes in nineteenth century America, see

James Oliver Horton, *Free People of Color: Inside the African American Community* (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution, 1993), 122–144.

⁴⁹ 1880 United States Census.

⁵⁰ 1880 United States Census.

⁵¹ This information about George Washington Henderson is available at www.vermontcivilwar.org/units/8/henderson.php (website accessed April 8, 2006).

⁵² Lee, *Black Bangor*, 8–9; 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census.

⁵³ Pleck, *Black Migration*, 46; 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census.

⁵⁴ Lee, *Black Bangor*, 13; Pleck, *Black Migration*, 47–49, 92–93.

⁵⁵ Harvey Amani Whitfield, *Blacks on the Border: The Black Refugees in British North America, 1815–1860* (Burlington: University of Vermont Press; Hanover: University Press of New England, 2006).

⁵⁶ Robert L. Hall and Michael M. Harvey, eds., *Making a Living: The Work Experience of African-Americans in New England, Selected Readings* (Boston: New England Foundation for the Humanities, 1995), 132.

⁵⁷ Gene Sessions, “‘Years of Struggle’: The Irish in the Village of Northfield, 1845–1900,” *Vermont History* 55 (Spring 1987): 69–95.

⁵⁸ Guyette, “Working Lives of Afro-Vermonters,” 69–84.

⁵⁹ Lee, *Black Bangor*, 52.

⁶⁰ Pleck, *Black Migration*, 129.

⁶¹ *Ibid.*, 128, 104.

⁶² James Oliver Horton and Lois E. Horton, *Black Bostonians: Family Life and Community Struggle in the Antebellum North* (1979; reprint, New York: Holmes and Meier, 1999), 10.

⁶³ 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census.

⁶⁴ Bassett, *The Growing Edge*, 197.

⁶⁵ 1880 United States Census.

⁶⁶ *Ibid.*

⁶⁷ Bassett, *The Growing Edge*, 208–210.

⁶⁸ 1880 United States Census.

⁶⁹ Beattie, “Migrants and Millworkers,” 103.

⁷⁰ 1880 United States Census.

⁷¹ *Burlington City Directory, 1886–87*, 5, 19, 59; 1880 United States Census.

⁷² *Burlington City Directory, 1889–90*, 247–248.

⁷³ *Burlington City Directory, 1894*, 265–266.

⁷⁴ 1880 United States Census.

⁷⁵ *Ibid.*

⁷⁶ Sessions, “Years of Struggle,” 74.

⁷⁷ 1880 United States Census.

⁷⁸ Sessions, “Years of Struggle,” 74.

⁷⁹ Sharon Harley, “For the Good of Family and Race: Gender, Work, and Domestic Roles in the Black Community, 1880–1930,” *Signs* 15 (Winter 1990): 337.

⁸⁰ 1880 United States Census.

⁸¹ *Ibid.*

⁸² *Ibid.*; 1900 United States Census.

⁸³ Sessions, “Years of Struggle,” 89.

⁸⁴ Pleck, *Black Migration*, 122–124; Stephan Thernstrom, *The Other Bostonians: Poverty and Progress in an American Metropolis* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1973).

⁸⁵ Bassett, *The Growing Edge*, 178.

⁸⁶ 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census.

⁸⁷ *Ibid.*

⁸⁸ *Ibid.*; 1900 United States Census. I have identified the following people as remaining in Burlington (they are listed by men, women, and children from 1880 census). Abial Anthony, George Williams, A. Davis, Leander Freeman (this person’s last name seems to be different in the 1900 census, but the ages, place of birth, and parents’ place of birth all match up; also Leander is listed in the 1900 city directory), William Watkins, Madison Paxton, Jacob Bland, John Jones, Clara Anthony, Mary Thomas, Nettie Williams, Eliza Anthony, Rachel Freeman, Gertrude Freeman, William Johnson, Grace Anthony, Victoria Williams, and Lucinda Smith.

⁸⁹ 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census.

⁹⁰ *Ibid.*

⁹¹ *Ibid.*

⁹² *Ibid.*

⁹³ *Ibid.*

⁹⁴ *Ibid.*; *Burlington City Directory, 1895*, 75.

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⁹⁵ 1880 United States Census; 1900 United States Census.

⁹⁶ *Burlington City Directory, 1896*, 137, 168.

⁹⁷ *Burlington City Directory, 1898*, 166; *Burlington City Directory, 1899*, 111.

⁹⁸ *Burlington City Directory, 1894*, 259; *Burlington City Directory, 1895*, 271; *Burlington City Directory, 1896*, 276; *Burlington City Directory, 1898*, 278.

⁹⁹ *Burlington City Directory, 1889/90; Burlington City Directory, 1895*.

¹⁰⁰ *Burlington City Directory, 1889/90; Burlington City Directory, 1899*.

¹⁰¹ Bassett, *The Growing Edge*, 197.

¹⁰² *Burlington City Directory, 1886/87*.

¹⁰³ *Burlington City Directory, 1889–90*, 147.

¹⁰⁴ *Ibid.*, 120.

¹⁰⁵ *Ibid.*

¹⁰⁶ *Burlington City Directory, 1900*.

¹⁰⁷ Noel Ignatiev, *How the Irish Became White* (New York: Routledge, 1995).



Learn More



America's public, partisan and passionate campaigns fired up uniformed young men who participated in torchlit marches, a style pioneered by the Republican Wide Awakes stumping for Abraham Lincoln in 1860 (above: a procession stomped through Lower Manhattan's Printing House Square). © Corbis via Getty Images

AT THE SMITHSONIAN | APRIL 27, 2021

19th-Century America's Partisan Warfare

In a new book, Smithsonian curator Jon Grinspan examines the history of America's furious and fractious politics



Jon Grinspan

Curator, political history, National Museum of American History

Nearly every day while writing my new book, *The Age of Acrimony: How American's Fought to Fix Their Democracy*, I would walk across the National Mall

in Washington, D.C., to my office at the Smithsonian's National Museum of American History. I'd pass tourists wearing MAGA hats and protestors waving angry signs. In the museum's secure collections, I'd settle into the cool, quiet aisles that preserve the deep history of our democracy. There, century-old objects—torches from midnight rallies, uniforms from partisan street gangs, ballots from stolen elections—told a forgotten drama of fractious and furious partisanship.

Most people don't often think about the politics of the late 1800s. Call it "historical flyover country," an era stranded between more momentous times, when U.S. presidents had funny names and silly facial hair. But for our current political crisis, this period is the most relevant, vital and useful. The nation's wild elections saw the highest turnouts and the closest margins, as well as a peak in political violence. Men and women campaigned, speechified and fought



Google



In 1910, the influential Kansas journalist and eventual leader of the progressive movement William Allen White wrote: "The real danger from democracy is that sobering up into the more temperate style of 20th-century America."

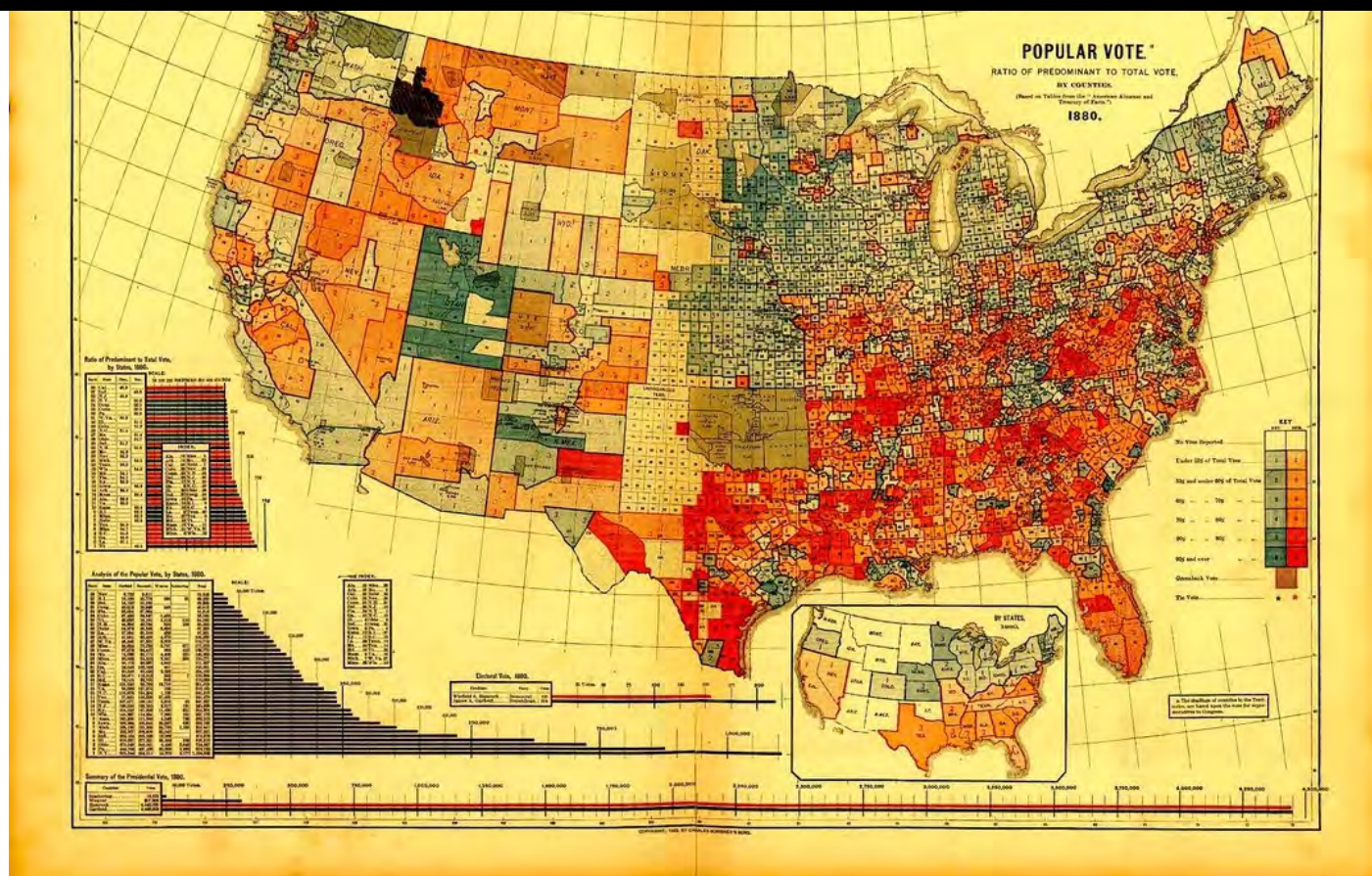


In 1889, a century after the birth of the U.S. Constitution, political cartoons of the era mocked the thuggish bosses and sleazy reporters, who dominated late 19th-century democracy, a far cry from the august Founding Fathers. "1789 to 1889—The Progress of Time," *Judge*, political history division, NMAH

Though we rightly think of 19th-century politics as exclusionary, American democracy held revolutionary new promise in the mid-1800s. For all its flaws, the nation was experimenting with a bold new system of government—one of the first in world history to give decisive political power to people without wealth, land or title. Working-class voters predominated at the polls. Poor boys grew up to be president. And reformers fought for votes for women and Black Americans.

Americans began to talk about “pure democracy.” That concept was never well defined, but for many activists, it meant that it was time for the people to rule. But how to get a busy, distractable, diverse nation to participate?

Decades earlier—from the 1820s to the 1850s—campaigners tried to engage voters by building bonfires, holding barbecues and offering plenty of stump speeches while handing out booze. Then, on the eve of the Civil War, supporters of Abe Lincoln’s hit on a new style. Lincoln’s Republican party introduced the “Wide Awakes” clubs to America. Gangs of young partisans, wearing dark, shimmering martial uniforms and armed with flaming torches, stormed through towns and cities in midnight marches. For the half century after 1860, every political campaign worth mentioning borrowed this approach, organizing massive rallies of tens of thousands of uniformed, torch-waving marchers. Diverse crowds turned out, from boisterous veteran voters to rowdy boys, from grandmothers to young women, from journalists armed with pens to political rivals armed with their revolvers.



This 1880 presidential election map is the first to depict county-level results, revealing the depths of partisan division in the closest popular vote election in U.S. history. Scribner's Sons, 1883. Geography and Map Division, Library of Congress, Washington, D.C.

Such public politics became, in the words of one comedian, “our great American game.” Political rancor grew precipitously. Saloons resounded with heated debates. On train cars, Americans took straw polls to see how strangers would vote. At dinner tables, families bonded—or broke up—debating an upcoming race. Even when exhausted Americans threw down their newspapers, they looked up only to find partisan broadsides slathered on every wall. “Ignorance is bliss now,” complained one woman as she canceled her political newspapers, weary of the whole spectacle.

For voters, participation meant an even deeper immersion. Election Day was a communal, combative, boozy bacchanal. White’s metaphor was apt, when people voted, they literally got drunk on Election Day. One Norwegian wrote

During the 1876 election, which drew an unprecedented 81.8 percent turnout—Rutherford B. Hayes’s campaign handed out massive oversize beer steins, despite the fact that Hayes and his wife were devout teetotalers.

All the carousing culminated at a rambunctious polling place, when a voter selected a colorful ticket from his party’s ballot “peddlers,” made his way past the opposing party’s intimidating “challengers,” and placed his vote in a wooden or glass ballot box. Amid singing, shouting and heckling from the other voters in his community, it was a scene of heated, convulsive political theater. The system seemed designed to take over life, distort opinions, attract bad actors, raise voices and destroy civility.

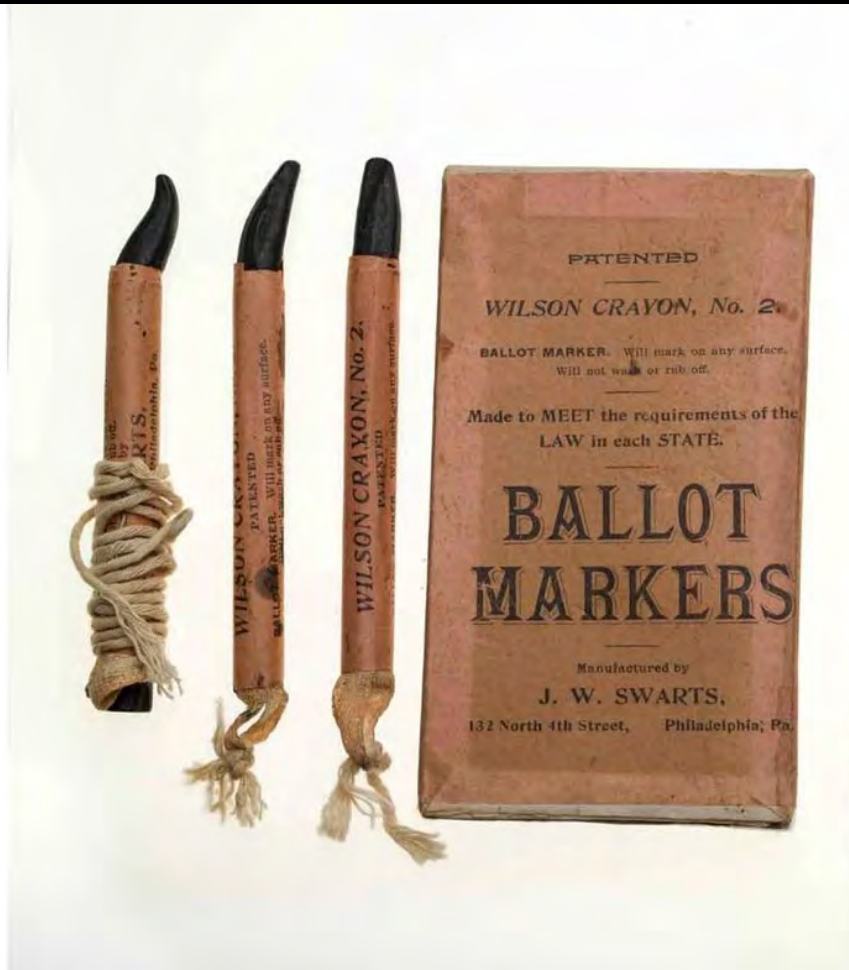


In political headquarters like this Republican office in 1896, African-Americans voters and politicians campaigned for candidates and fought to maintain their tenuous hold on new and embattled voting rights.
NMAH, political history division

In northern cities, a sneering establishment worried that the system was dominated by a working-class majority who could always outvote them. The celebrated Boston aristocrat Francis Parkman famously complained that democracy didn’t work in his 1878 “The Failure of Universal Suffrage,” a screed that claimed that the voters were “a public pest” and that the real threat to

Equal suffrage met even more aggressive attacks in the South. White supremacist ex-Confederates, who lost the war and had remained on the fringes of politics for most of a decade after, used the Democratic party to terrorize Black voters, end Reconstruction and dramatically suppress voter participation. Within a few short years of the end of slavery, one million formerly enslaved Americans became voters, but most lost their rights nearly as quickly as Reconstruction ended and the Jim Crow era began.

In the North, voter turnouts peaked from 1876 to 1896, and elections were never closer. No president in this period came to office by winning a majority of the popular vote. Even with racial issues falling out of the national spotlight, fights over money and inequality fired up voters.



4 / 4



As revolutionary reforms replaced noisy public elections with quiet, bureaucratic and secret voting, ballot markers like these played a key role in redesigning American democracy to benefit literate, educated and wealthy voters, at the expense of the less educated, whose turnout dropped precipitously. NMAH, political history division

Though the electorate turned out in huge numbers, marchers filled squares and newspapers attacked rivals, politics failed to bring real change. This system—overheating and yet standing still—led only to anger and agitation. In 1881, the mentally ill drifter Charles Guiteau, who had campaigned for President James Garfield at torchlit rallies, felt slighted and decided that America would be better off if the “President was out of the way.” So Guiteau bought the

madman would gun down President William McKinley. And every seven years, on average, a sitting congressman was murdered.

American politics had hit on an amazing ability to mobilize citizens, but also to agitate them to unspeakable violence. Citizens looked for someone to blame. Presidents were criticized, but really the executive branch was so weak that they could do very little. Powerful party bosses often nominated friendly, malleable do-nothings to the job. More people blamed politicians as a class. Brilliant cartoonists like Thomas Nast and Joseph Keppler mocked politicians as snarling beasts, overfed vultures, sniveling rats and thuggish bosses. Others attacked the rising immigration rates, like Francis Willard, the leader of the Women's Christian Temperance Union, who blamed America's out-of-control politics on "alien illiterates." Others still aimed (more accurate) attacks at railroads, corporations, robber barons and lobbyists who seemed to be buying up America. The muckraking reporter Henry Demarest Lloyd wrote that "liberty produces wealth, and wealth destroys liberty."

Everybody, it seemed in the grumpy 1880s, had someone to blame for why democracy was failing.

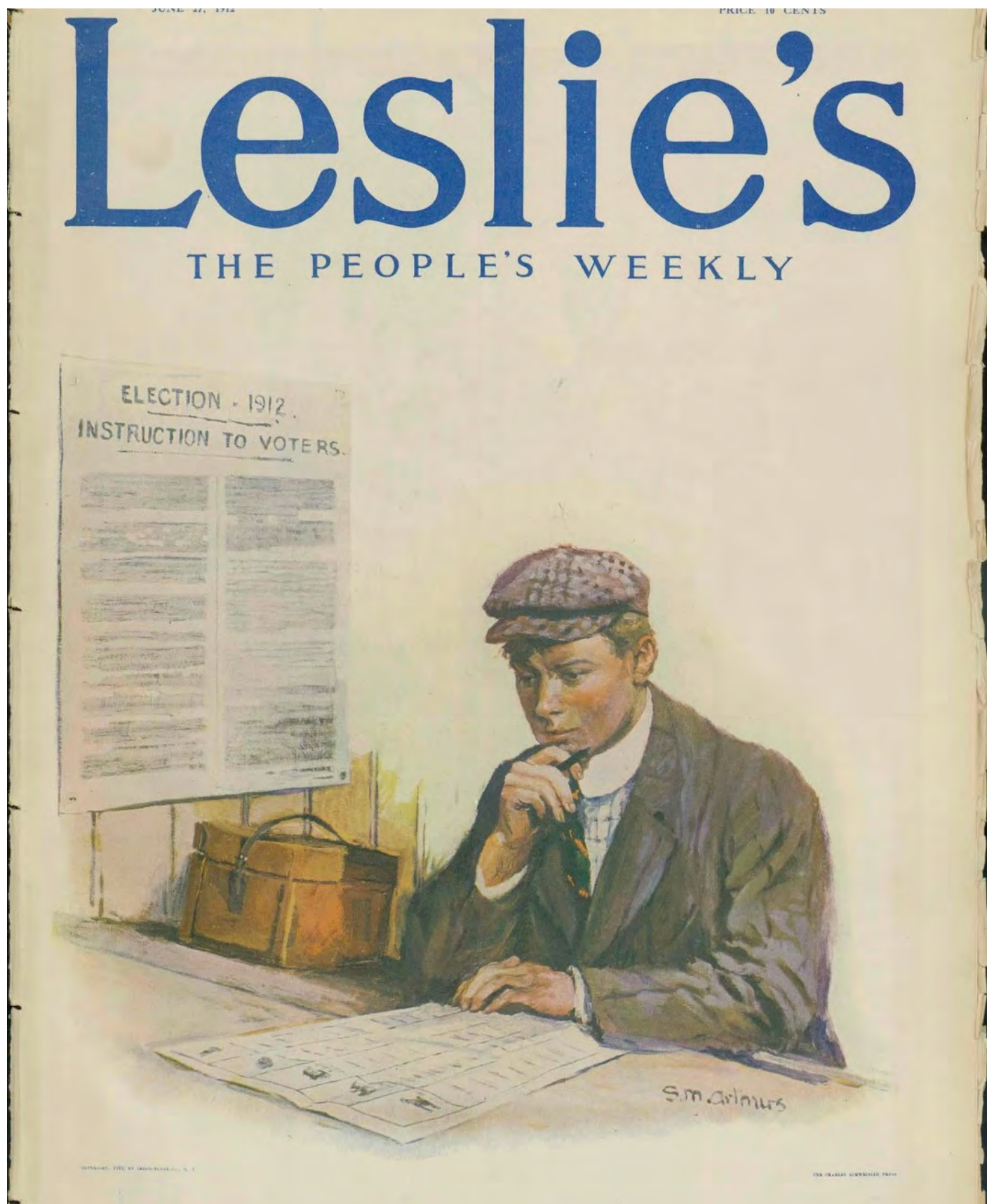


Some well-to-do reformers blamed, not individuals or groups, but the culture and etiquette of American democracy. All those noisy rallies were nothing more than a “silly sort of show,” those busy polling places were “vulgar,” “venal” and “filthy.” American democracy, a growing upper middle-class movement argued, needed an intervention, and in an era of Temperance politics, reformers knew just how to achieve it.

First, they went after the booze. Reform organizations pulled the liquor licenses from political fundraisers, closed saloons on Election Day and passed prohibition laws on the county and state level. Voters were more clearheaded, but those partisan saloons had been key institutions for working-class men. Shutting them down meant shutting many out.

Cities banned marches without permits and used police and militias to punish unlawful assembly. And parties desperate to win over “the *better* class of people,” as one reformer put it, stopped paying for torches, uniforms, fireworks and whiskey. Campaigners shifted from thrilling street-corner oratory to printed pamphlets. To some, these changes looked like innovations. *The Los Angeles Times* cheered the citizens who had spent previous elections “on the street corner shouting, or in the torchlight procession,” but could now be “found at home” reading quietly.

Voting itself changed in small but crucial ways. Starting in 1887, state after state switched to the secret ballot—a dense government form that was cast privately—and dispatched with party-printed tickets. By isolating each voter “alone with his conscience” in the polling booth, or behind a voting machine’s curtain, he was certainly made more reflective, but also more removed. Those who could not read English, who had previously voted by color-coded ballots, were out of luck with the complicated machines, text-heavy ballots or unsympathetic poll workers. And those who participated in Election Day



In the early 20th century the new model of a voter was a single, well-off looking man pondering his conscience, usually while stroking his chin. "The Man who Will Elect the Next President," Leslie's: *The People's Weekly*, June 27, 1912; NMAH

Popular Science

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HOW TO USE
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Some white, middle class Americans bragged about low voter turnouts. "It was gratifying," reported an Augusta, Georgia, newspaper in 1904 "to see voting booths free of noisy crowds." "How to Use the Voting

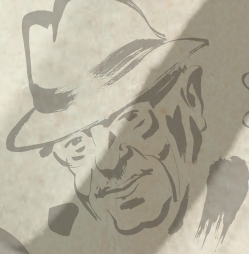
Predictably, turnout crashed. In the 1896 presidential election, 80 percent of eligible Americans were still voting, but by 1924, voter participation plummeted to fewer than 49 percent. Voters who were poorer, younger, less well-educated, African American, or immigrants or children of immigrants were especially shut out of the political arena. White, middle class Americans cheered the trend, with some even bragging about the low turnouts. “It was gratifying,” reported an Augusta, Georgia, newspaper in 1904 “to see voting booths free of noisy crowds.”

The revolution lasted for a century. What Americans now consider “normal politics” was really stifled Democracy, the post-intervention cool, calm model—lower drama but lower participation. Now, however, those old tendencies may be creeping back.

Around the turn of the 20th century, Americans flooded newspapers, magazines, clubs and street corners with a public debate over America’s chief values. A similar moment is emerging today, with a public more self-aware and reflective about democracy than during apathetic eras. Tribalism, division and “general cussedness” (as they used to call it) is up, but so is attention and turnout. The two might go hand-in-hand; the 2020 election was the first since 1900 to boast turnouts above 66 percent. “The most hopeful sign of the times,” as William Allen White reminded anxious readers in 1910, “is that we are beginning to get a national sense of our ailment.” The first step towards recovery is admitting that we have a problem.



WILDER
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OUR TOWN Quoted from T.W.:

The play ~~is~~ is an attempt to find a value above all price for the smallest events in our daily life.

But that is about. The generations of men follow upon one another in apparently endless repetition. They are born; they grow up; they marry; they have children; they die. Where shall we seek a "value above all price" in these recurrent situations?

On the stage it is always now.

THORNTON WILDER
SOME THOUGHTS ON PLAYWRITING, 1941

I think of my work as being French in form and manners (Saint-Simon and La Bruyère); German in feeling (Bach and Beethoven); and American in eagerness.

— Thornton Wilder, 1929

April 17, 1897



Born in Madison, Wisconsin. Twin brother dies at birth, leaving haunting presence throughout his life. Father is a journalist, orator, and diplomat. Mother is passionate about languages and the arts. One of five siblings, two boys and three girls. Four become writers and one a scientist.

1906-10

Family moves to Hong Kong where father is appointed U.S. Consul General. Seeking better schooling, mother and

children return within months to the United States, settling in Berkeley California. Wilder attends public schools. Studies piano and violin, sings in choirs. Haunts Greek Theatre in the Berkeley Hills.



1910-11

Father, promoted to Consularship in Shanghai, attempts to reunite family in China. Mother soon moves to Italy with younger children. Wilder attends China

Inland Mission (boarding) School in Chefoo (now Yantai), Northern China. Recollections of poverty and cholera epidemic beyond school walls remain indelible memories throughout his life.

1912-15

Attends Thacher (boarding) School in Ojai, California for one year. Stages and stars in his first known play, *The Russian Princess*.



Returns home to family in Berkeley (father still posted in China). Attends Berkeley High School where active in multiple dramatic groups. Attending local theaters and spending time in university library. Begins writing disciplined 3-minute plays for 3 actors ("playlets"). Graduates from Berkeley High School in 1915.

1915-17

Two happy years at Oberlin College. Publishes five playlets, among other writings. Studies with a professor of English who encourages a gratefully acknowledged lifelong passion for classical literature. During summers, father, worried



about the long-term prospects of his aesthetically-minded son, arranges "shirtsleeve" jobs on farms in California, Kentucky, Vermont, and Massachusetts. Wilder will come to deeply appreciate these experiences as part of his education.

1917-20

Having permitted his artistic passions to distract him from his studies, Wilder must repeat sophomore year.

Spends three years at Yale, amasses publications, among them eleven playlets and a full-length play, *The Trumpet Shall Sound* (produced off-Broadway in 1926). Wins prizes for fiction and drama. Writes drama criticism for important Boston paper. Majors in English and minors in Latin.

1918

Spends three months in the U.S. Army stationed at Ft. Adams, Newport, Rhode Island ("rising by sheer genius to the rank of Corporal"). Stay inspires a lifelong passion for Newport celebrated in last novel, *Theophilus North* (1973).

**We can only be said to be
alive in those moments
when our hearts are
conscious of our treasure.**

THORNTON WILDER
THE WOMAN OF ANDROS, 1930

I seem to be living in Italy for the sole purpose of receiving the confidence of ladies in distress. The tales of woe, broken engagements, insult, and injury I've had to listen to from grande dame to servant-girl would freeze your spine. There's something in the air over here: everyone is unhappily in love every minute of their lives. — *Wilder to his sister, Isabel, April 4, 1921*

1920-21

To improve credentials for possibly teaching Latin, parents arrange an eight-month residency at the American Academy in Rome. Arrives in Rome in November 1920 having written a play along the way (*The Villa Rahbani*, produced for the first time in Naples in 2018). In addition to attending AAR lectures and field archeology events, spends busy weeks exploring the Eternal City



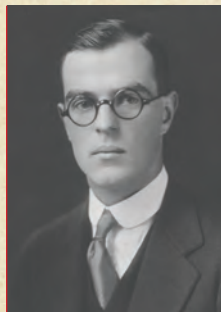
and attending theater, music, and social events of all kinds. Stay in Rome proves significant experience that resonates far into his future as a writer.

1921

Visits Paris in late spring and summer where, inspired by experiences in Rome, he begins first novel (*The Cabala*) in a cheap Left Bank hotel. Receives offer to teach French and handle dormitory duties at The Lawrenceville School, a boarding school for boys in New Jersey. Returns from Europe to a much-needed life experience — a job!

1921-25

Enjoys life as a busy French teacher and



dorm master. Writing *The Cabala* in evenings. Spends free moments in the nearby Princeton Library and attends theater from Philadelphia to New York. In summer of 1924, makes his first visit to the MacDowell Colony, a writers' retreat in Peterborough, New Hampshire, where he would return some 10 times throughout his career.

1925

New York publishing firm, A & C Boni offers to publish *The Cabala* based on a partial manuscript. The now 28-year-old Wilder combines fulltime graduate studies in French literature at Princeton with completing novel.

1926

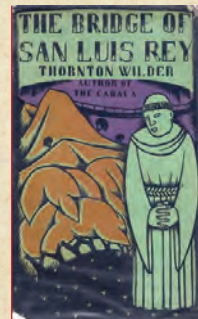
The Cabala is published to critical acclaim in the U.S. and England.



Receives M.A. from Princeton. Richard Bole-slowski, who introduced the Stanislavsky method in the U.S., directs *The Trumpet Shall Sound* in repertory in New York City's innovative American Laboratory Theatre and School (the "Lab"). Play was a mixed success.

1927-28

Returns to Lawrenceville one last time. Becomes overnight literary sensation with publication of *The Bridge of San Luis Rey*. Wins Pulitzer Prize. Elected to American Academy of Arts and Letters (Institute). Now moving among important artistic circles. Becomes friend of producer-director



Jed Harris. Publishes first book of plays, *The Angel That Troubled The Waters And Other Plays*, composed of playlets.

1929

Gives first of 144 professionally managed lectures throughout the country. These addresses reveal him as erudite and a wonderfully entertaining speaker. (Contract not fulfilled until 80 by 1937.) Now traveling abroad.

**Many persons are
at their most amiable
when saying goodbye.**

THORNTON WILDER
THE EIGHTH DAY, 1957

My life has variety. The other night I had supper (4 AM) as the guest of Jack McGurn (Capone's chief representative) and Sam (Hunt) the golf bag killer. Tonight I dine at Mrs. Rockefeller McCormick's off the gold plate that Napoleon gave Josephine. Variety, variety.

— Wilder to his attorney January 18, 1932, about life in Chicago

1930

Accepts part-time position at the University of Chicago teaching lecture class on Classics in Translation and a seminar on Composition. (Holds position until 1936 and in 1940/1941.) Publishes *The Woman of Andros*, third best-selling novel in 1930. In June, family moves into Hamden, CT home — “The House The Bridge Built,” now his legal address and base to which he returns for a part of each year. *Bridge* also pays for a grand piano and Wilder's first car.

1931

The Long Christmas Dinner and Other Plays in One Act, six one-acts, published in both trade and expensive “boxed”

editions. Plays celebrate different theatrical forms, among them, classic, tragedy, boulevard humor and farce. All receive world premieres on campus stages in New Haven, Chicago and Yellow Springs, Ohio. Some, including *The Happy Journey to Trenton and Camden*, *The Long Christmas Dinner* and *Queens of France*, are soon performed by a growing number of amateur theatrical groups across the country.



1932

Adapts Ottó Indig's *The Bride of Torozko* from its German trans. for



producer Gilbert Miller (version never produced). Translates André Obey's French play, *The Rape of Lucrece*, for Katharine Cornell (success in Cleveland and Buffalo but failure on Broadway). Now writing a picaresque novel, *Heaven's My Destination*, featuring a traveling salesman named

George Brush who tries to lead a blameless life. (Wilder will later write: “George Brush—that's me.”)

1934

Undertakes screenwriting assignments on several films and a never produced film treatment for *Joan of Arc*. Proves wildly popular as a personality in Hollywood. Completes *Heaven's My Destination* at Mabel Dodge Luhan's fabled ranch in Taos, New Mexico. Meets Alice B. Toklas and Gertrude Stein for first time in Chicago, becoming their lifelong friend. (Will write three introductions for Stein's works over the next thirteen years.)



1935-36

Heaven's My Destination proves bestseller. A devoted admirer and student of the Baroque sensibility, Wilder adapts and stage directs Handel's *Xerxes*, with a part in the chorus for himself in this nationally noted University of Chicago production. Among several plays he's now writing, one, “M marries N,” the first sign of *Our Town* (phrase used by Stage Manager

in Act II). Father dies. Traveling abroad.

1937

Adapts Ibsen's *A Doll's House* for Jed Harris and actress Ruth Gordon. (Sets a 144-performance Broadway record)



for the work not broken until 1997.) Serves as first American delegate to the Institute for International Cooperation in Paris; all but completes *Our Town* in late fall in Switzerland. Also working on *The Merchant of Yonkers*, a farce.

Oh, yes, - it's a risk. One may be making a great mistake. But without risks, there is no adventure and no savor. But (intimately) remember this: The mistakes we make through generosity do us less harm than anything else. People, even before we're artists. The role of being a Person is sufficient to have lived and died for.

THORNTON WILDER
LETTER TO HIS SISTER, ISABEL WILDER, 1937

WAS OFFERED AND TURNED DOWN SOLO JOB ON NEXT GARBO PICTURE STOP ROLLER SKATED WITH WALT DISNEY TAOS NEXT TUESDAY LOVE = THORNTON.

— Telegram to mother, September 8, 1934, from Hollywood

1938

After wobbly Boston try-out, *Our Town*, directed by Jed Harris, opens with enormous success on Broadway on Feb. 4, (five weeks after *A Doll's House* opening) Runs 336 performances. Awarded Pulitzer Prize. Wilder makes his Broadway acting debut, performing role of the Stage Manager for three weeks. *The Merchant of Yonkers* opens on Broadway December 28, directed by the world-renowned Max Reinhardt. Closes after only thirty-nine performances.

es. "Show business is funny," says Wilder.

1939

Extensive travel to Europe visiting people like Stein, Henry and Clare Booth Luce, and Sigmund Freud. Performs role of the Stage Manager in four different summer productions of *Our Town*. Refuses fee for extensive work on *Our*



Town screenplay, but receives Christmas present of a Chrysler Convertible from producer Sol

Lessor. Adapting *The Beaux' Stratagem* for Cheryl Crawford and writing major essay on the nature of playwriting. Now deeply into decoding *Finnegans Wake*, a passion that will last for years.

1940

Stirred by news of the war in Europe and inspired by James Joyce, begins working on a play titled *The End of the Worlds*, which will become *The Skin of Our Teeth*.

1941

Puts aside work on *The Skin of Our Teeth* to travel to Columbia, Ecuador, and Peru for several months at request of the State Department's Bureau of Cultural

Affairs. Delivers lectures in Spanish. Travels to England as a delegate to a PEN conference. Experienced London blackout. Toured several bombed-out cities in Great Britain.

1942

Completes *The Skin of Our Teeth*. Accepted into the Army Air Force Intelligence declaring he would take "the khaki veil with an explosive cry of relief." Before reporting for duty, collaborates with Alfred Hitchcock on the screenplay for *Shadow of a Doubt*.



After complicated try-outs in three cities, *Skin*, directed by Elia Kazan, opens successfully on Broadway November 18.



1943

Receives third Pulitzer Prize for *The Skin of Our Teeth*. In April, assigned overseas duty with the intelligence section of the Twelfth Air Force in Constantine, Algeria, and later Algiers.

1944

Now Lt.Col. Wilder, posted to Caserta, Italy. While there, directs an all-military production of *Our Town*. Second film adaptation of *The Bridge of San Luis Rey* is released (third to come in 2004).



1945

Receives Bronze Star, returns to the United States and discharged in May. Puts *The Alcestiad* aside to begin novel *The Ides of March*.

**Anyway: what's life if
it isn't risk, venture,
taxes on the willpower,
diversity, and fun?**

THORNTON WILDER
LETTER TO ALEXANDER WOOLLCOTT, JULY 1938

The novelist must be more interested in human beings than in forming generalized ideas about human beings; and he must believe profoundly in the principle of freedom in the life of the human mind.— *Thornton Wilder, on receiving Gold Medal for Fiction, American Academy of Arts and Letters, 1952*

1946

Meets Jean-Paul Sartre at Yale who asks him to translate his play, *Morts sans sépulture*. Mother dies on June 29. Receives Order of the British Empire (O.B.E.) for wartime service.

1947

Spends a month in Mexico and moves on to Florida, finishing *The Ides of March*.

1948

Consults in London on Laurence Olivier's



production of *The Skin of Our Teeth* starring Vivien Leigh. *The Ides of March* is a publishing success and selected for Book of the Month Club. Plays Mr. Antrobus and the Stage Manager in summer-stock productions of *The Skin of Our Teeth* and *Our Town*. Now deeply into Lope de Vega scholarship. Lectures in German universities. His translation of *Morts sans sépulture*, produced off-Broadway as *The Victors*, opens to mixed reviews.



THE ANTROBUS FAMILY and SABINA

1949

Indebted to Existentialism (among many sources), begins *The Emporium*, a major play he will never complete. Visits Ezra Pound at St. Elizabeth's Hospital. Delivers lecture at Goethe Bicentennial at the Aspen Festival where he also translates for attending participants Albert Schweitzer in German and José Ortega y Gasset in Spanish.

1950

Accepts Charles Eliot Norton Professorship of Poetry at Harvard for 1950-1951 academic year. Position requires six public lectures, delivered and published. Lectures on Thoreau, Poe, Melville, Dickenson, and Whitman in series titled,

"The American Characteristics in Classic American Literature." Following the death of F. O. Matthiessen, he also steps in to teach large Harvard lecture course. Accepts invitations for lectures, talks, and meeting with students and groups throughout Boston area.

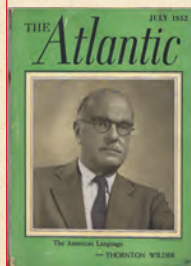
1951

Collapses from exhaustion and hospitalized for several weeks. Resumes lighter schedule. Gives the Harvard Alumni Association's Commencement Address. New hobby: reading sheet music. Calls Harvard experience the hardest year of his life.

1952

Awarded the Gold Med-

al for Fiction from The American Academy of Arts and Letters. Travels to Paris to meet with Ruth Gordon and Tyrone Guthrie who have asked him to revise *The Merchant of Yonkers*. His photo on the cover

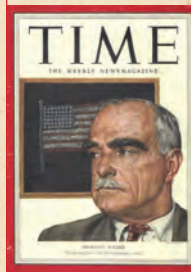


of *The Atlantic Monthly* is tied to publication of his three Norton lectures in that journal, the only three ever published.

1953

Featured on the cover of *Time*, January 1953.

Works on *The Emporium* and revising *The Merchant of Yonkers*.

**1954**

Directed by Tyrone Guthrie and starring Ruth Gordon, *The Merchant of Yonkers* opens successfully as *The Matchmaker* at the Edinburgh Festival, and then in London. Continues work on *The Alcestiad*, which he describes "a humdinger—the true extension of the *Our Town-Skin* line."

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SYLVIA BEACH
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LUK DORON
LOCK THE DOOR

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LUKIFER = LO-SH

Literature has always
more resembled a torch
race than a furious
dispute among heirs.

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drops by deep request.

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hu, how the hue, where the huer? Orbiter onswers: l
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4) Narrat. poem by Blisrael

3) Is this Alex... angels and lookella - as on p. 251: 19

8) ... called wood

THORNTON WILDER
PREFACE TO THREE PLAYS, 1957

Ma, I don't want to grow old. Why's everybody pushing me so?

— *George Gibbs to his mother, Our Town, Act II*

1955-56

The Alcestiad opens at the Edinburgh Festival directed by Guthrie, starring Irene Worth, to generally negative reviews. Wilder begins collaborating with American composer Louise Talma on a grand opera based on *The Alcestiad*. After a smash-hit run in London, *Matchmaker* sets a Wilder Broadway record of 486 performances. Wilder travels to different continents to work and “regenerate.”

1957

Travels to Europe—to Brussels to see *The Matchmaker* performed in French; to Bonn where he is inducted into the Orden Pour le Mérite für Wissenschaften und Künste; to

Switzerland for rehearsals of a German-language production of *The Alcestiad* which was well-received in Zurich and soon performed widely throughout Germany. Three one-act plays, *The Happy Journey to Trenton and Camden*, and two new ones, *Bernice* and *The Wreck on the Five-Twenty-Five* performed at new Congress Hall in West Berlin. Becomes the first American to receive the German Booksellers Peace Prize in Frankfurt. Delivers address, “Culture in a Democracy,” in German to audience of more than two thousand.

1958

Launches two cycles of one-act plays, *The*

Seven Ages of Man and *The Seven Deadly Sins*, for the Arena Stage. Paramount Pictures releases *The Matchmaker* starring Shirley Booth, Anthony Perkins, and Shirley MacLaine.



1959

Spends part of year in Europe, writing. Plays Stage Manager in *Our Town* at Williamstown, MA, his final appearance as an actor.



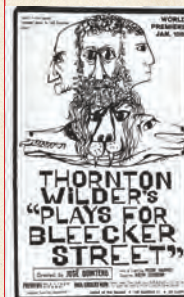
1960-61

Works on his *Ages and Sins* cycles. Adapts *The Long Christmas Dinner* as a one-act opera for composer Paul Hindemith. Work premiered successfully in Mannheim, West Germany, in December 1961. (Opera continues to be performed.)

1962-64

Plays for Bleeker Street, composed of one *Sin* and two *Ages* (*Someone from Assisi, Infancy*,

and *Childhood*) opens with success off-Broad-



way. The potentially historic Wilder-Talma grand opera based on *The Alcestiad* with soprano Inge Borkh in title role opens in Frankfurt to 20-minute ovation but critical disdain for its serial music -- and remains unknown work. Presents “An Evening with Thornton Wilder,” a Kennedy cabinet-sponsored major cultural event in Wash-

ington, D.C. Exhausted, departs for the Arizona desert in May 1962. Car breaks down in Douglas, AZ, where he remains without phone for 20 months. Begins writing *The Eighth Day*, first novel in fifteen years. Leaves Douglas to accept the Presidential Medal of Freedom. *Hello, Dolly!* adapted



from *The Matchmaker*, opens on Broadway. Wins 10 Tony Awards including Best Musical, a record for the next 37 years.

Money ... is like manure;
it's not worth a thing
unless it's spread
about encouraging
young things to grow.

THORNTON WILDER

DOLLY LEVI, THE MATCHMAKER, ACT IV, 1954

Imagination draws on memory. Memory and imagination combined can stage a Servants' Ball or even write a book, if that's what they want to do. — *Concluding lines of Theophilus North, 1973*

1965

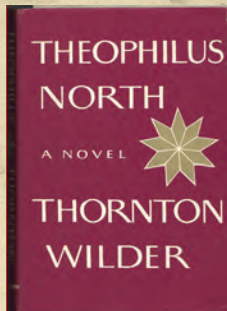
Continues to work almost exclusively on *The Eighth Day*. Lady Bird Johnson awards him National Book Committee's first Medal for Literature.

1967

The Eighth Day, Wilder's epic novel, published to enormous critical and popular acclaim. Receives the National Book Award for Fiction.

1968

Travels often, with visits to Paris, Munich, Milan, Venice, Zurich, Cannes, Florida, New York and Martha's Vineyard where he now has a house but only stays "out of season." Suffering circulatory, eye, and hearing problems.



1972-73

Drawing on his many visits to Newport, Rhode Island, writes, in a single year, his semi-autobiographical final novel, *Theophilus North*.

1973-74

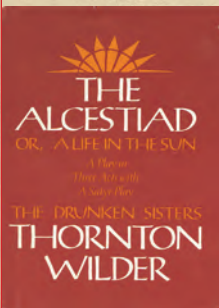
Theophilus North is published and becomes a bestseller. Continues to travel but spends most of his time closer to Hamden home.

1975

Wilder dies during an afternoon's nap at home in Hamden, Connecticut on December 7.

1977

The Alcestiad and its satyr play, *The Drunken Sisters*, published together by Harper & Row.



1979

American Characteristics and Other Essays published by Harper & Row.

1980

Amos N. Wilder publishes *Thornton Wilder and His Public*.

1985

The Journals of Thornton Wilder, 1939-1961, published by Yale University Press.

1986

Thornton Wilder Writing Competition established at Hamden Public Library.



1989

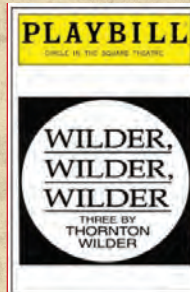
Our Town opens on Broadway at Lincoln Center Theater starring Spalding Gray; Tony Award for Best Revival of a Play.

1992

Conversations with Thornton Wilder edited by Jackson R. Bryer published by University Press of Mississippi.

1993

Wilder, Wilder, Wilder featuring *The Happy Journey to Trenton and Camden*, *The Long Christmas Dinner*, and *Pullman Car Hiawatha* opens at Circle in the Square; *Thornton Wilder, a Reference Guide 1926-1990*, Claudette Walsh, published by G.K. Hall & Co.



1995

Wilder's sister Isabel dies; Tappan Wilder becomes his uncle's literary executor; release of six previously unpublished one act plays: *Cement Hands*, *The Wreck on the Five-Twenty-Five*, *Bernice*, *In Shakespeare and the Bible*, *Youth*, and *The Rivers Under the Earth*.

The gift to the public of laughter without malice is one of the most useful things a man can do. Anyone can make a comedy which is cruel. It is hard to make a comedy that is kind. To give a fellow a feeling between the young and the old — that is art.

THORNTON WILDER

NEW YORK JOURNAL-AMERICAN INTERVIEW, AUGUST 8, 1958

Wilder took the given and raised it to the higher power of reflection. And he did it the hard way: by telling the truth. — *J.D. McClatchy, The New York Times, April 13, 1997*

1996

The Letters of Gertrude Stein and Thornton Wilder, Edited by Edward M. Burns and Ulla E. Dydo with William Rice, published by Yale University Press.

1997

Centenary of Wilder's birth. Kevin Kline stars in premiere reading of *Cement Hands* in New York; World premiere of four one-acts directed by Tazewell Thompson at Actors Theatre of Louisville; TCG publishes

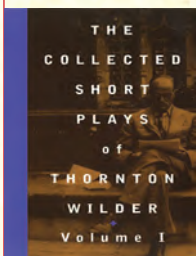
Wilder's one-acts in *The Collected Short Plays of Thornton Wilder* Volume 1; U.S. Postal Service issues Wilder stamp in Thornton



Wilder Hall, Hamden Public Library. Carol Channing performs first lick. Second day celebration in Madison, WI.

1998

TCG publishes *The Collected Short Plays of Thornton Wilder* Volume 2, containing 17 playlets, *The Alcestiad*, and scenes from Wilder's unfinished play, *The Emporium*.



1999

Thornton Wilder: New Essays, edited by Martin Blank, Dalma Brunauer, & David Garrett Izzo published by Locust Hill Press.

2000

The Thornton Wilder Society established.

2001

A Tour of the Darkling Plain: The Finnegans Wake Letters of Thornton Wilder and Adaline Glasheen published by University College Dublin Press.

2003

All of Wilder's novels back in print published by HarperCollins; *Our Town*, starring Paul Newman, opens on Broadway; Matthew Burnett's stage adapta-

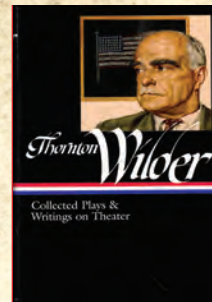
tion of *Theophilus North* opens in joint premiere by Arena Stage and the Geva Theatre Center.

2006

The Our Town opera, composed by Ned Rorem with libretto by J.D. McClatchy premieres at Indiana University on Feb 25. *The Beaux' Stratagem* opens at The Shakespeare Theatre in Washington, D.C., Ken Ludwig's completion of Thornton Wilder's adaptation.

2007-11

The Library of America publishes Wilder's drama, fiction, and essays in three volumes edited by J. D. McClatchy: *Thornton Wilder: Collected Plays & Writings on Theater* (2007); *The*



Bridge of San Luis Rey and Other Novels 1926-1948 (2009); *The Eighth Day*, *Theophilus North* and *Autobiographical Writings* (2011).

2008

The Selected Letters of Thornton Wilder, Edited by Robin G. Wilder & Jackson R. Bryer published by HarperCollins. Wilder Society gives its first Thornton Wilder Prize to Russell Banks.

2009

The American Academy of Arts and Letters bestows first biennial Thornton Wilder Prize for Translation; *Our Town* opens off-Broadway, directed by and

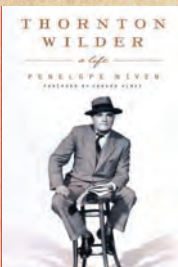


starring David Cromer. Becomes the longest running production of the play in its history. In addition to Cromer, other notable actors who perform the role of Stage Manager during the run include Helen Hunt, Michael McKean, Jason Butler Harner, Stephen Kunken and Michael Shannon.

**Where there is
an unknowable,
there is a promise.**

THORNTON WILDER
THE IDES OF MARCH, 1948

Wilder leaves you feeling that you haven't just watched a show. With the actors and other playgoers, you've tried to make a little better sense of the funny, scary, bewildering business of being alive. — *Jeremy McCarter, The New York Times, April 1, 2007*



2012

Thornton Wilder: A Life, by Penelope Niven, definitive biography, published by Harper-Collins.

2013

Thornton Wilder: New Perspectives, edited by Lincoln Konkle and Jackson R. Bryer, published by Northwestern University Press.

2016

Wilder's adapted version of *A Doll's House* published by TCG Press.

2017

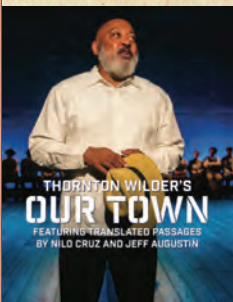
Hello, Dolly! revived on Broadway starring Bette Midler and Bernadette Peters; first multilingual production of *Our Town* premieres at Miami New Drama. Completion of Samuel French/Concord Theatricals reissue of all acting editions, including Wilder's definitive *Our Town*.



2018-19

David Greenspan's stage adaptation of *The Bridge of San Luis Rey* premieres at Two River Theater and Miami

New Drama; *Thornton Wilder in Collaboration*, essays Edited by Jackson R. Bryer, Judith P. Hallett and Edyta K. Oczkowicz, published Cambridge Scholars Publishing.



2020

Our Town (multilingual) acting edition published by Samuel French/Concord Theatricals.

2022

HarperCollins completes the Thornton

Wilder Library edition of Wilder's seven novels and three major plays. Greenspan's adaptation of *The Bridge of San Luis Rey*, published by Concord Theatricals. *The Skin of Our Teeth* opens on Broadway directed by Lileana Blain-Cruz.

2022-23

Celebration of Thornton Wilder's 125th birthday.



125
CELEBRATING 125 YEARS
OF THORNTON WILDER

BOOKS OF THE TIMES

A Life Captured With Luster Left Intact

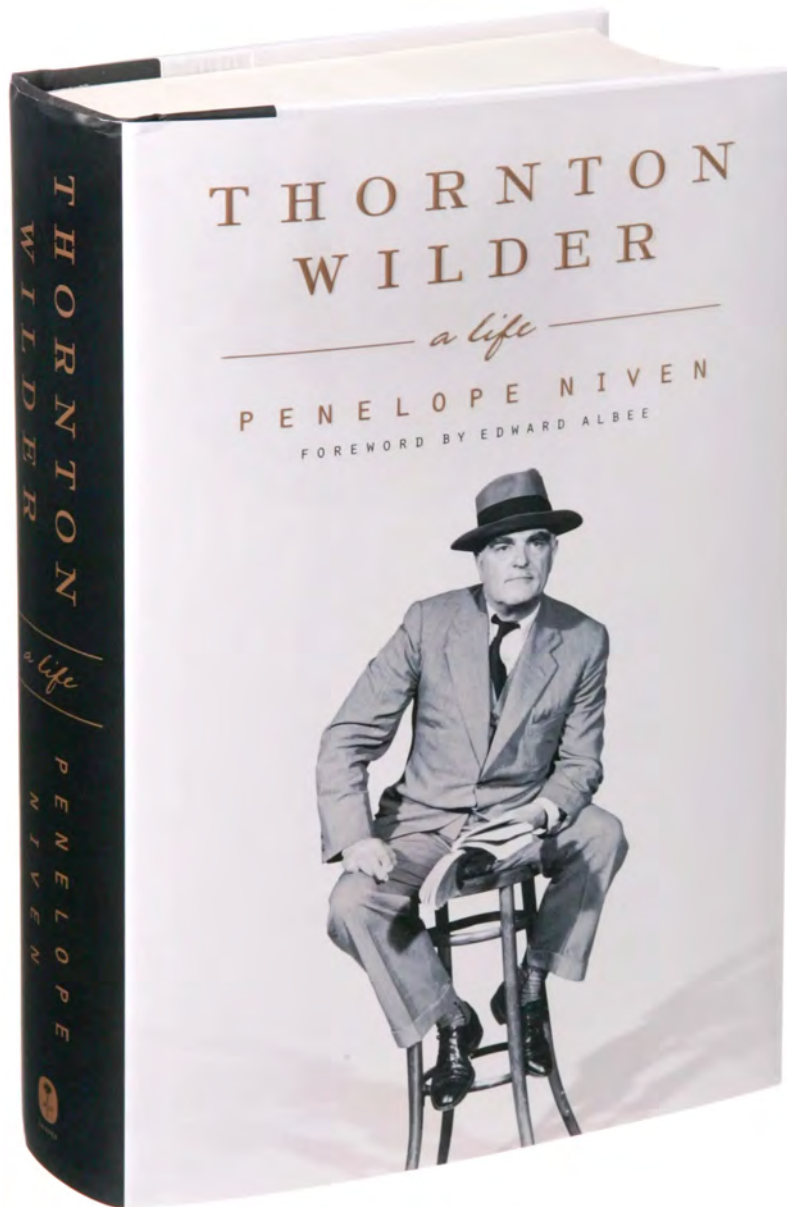
By Charles Isherwood

Oct. 31, 2012

“Art is confession; art is the secret told,” Thornton Wilder wrote shortly after fame and the first of his three Pulitzer Prizes had come to him in his early 30s. “But art is not only the desire to tell one’s secret; it is the desire to tell it and hide it at the same time.” That suggestive formulation is as evocative today as it was when Wilder penned it in 1928. But now we are more likely to associate specific literary genres with the heart’s hidden truths: the ever-billowing genre of memoir is confession, we might say, and biography is the secret told.

It’s probably unnecessary to add that the revelations such books traffic in are likely to be of the sensational variety, tales of turbulent relationships and dogged addictions.

Among the refreshing aspects of Penelope Niven’s new biography, “Thornton Wilder: A Life,” is its startling sexlessness, the paucity of the kind of dish that sometimes has seemed to drive the market in literary biography in recent decades. Ms. Niven, the author of books about Carl Sandburg and Edward Steichen, has dug deeply into the copiously documented life of her subject, drawing on access to substantial troves of previously undisclosed family papers. And yet, setting aside the dubious testimony of a single man who claims to have gone to bed with Wilder, “Thornton Wilder: A Life” tells of a life lived without the sexual relationships and romantic attachments that we sometimes falsely assume to be the most momentous passages in an artist’s — or anyone’s — life.



Patricia Wall/The New York Times

In a quotation from an essay that Ms. Niven uses as an epigraph for the book's preface, Wilder wrote that "the history of a writer is his search for his own subject, his myth-theme, hidden from him, but prepared for him in every hour of his life." She has taken her cue from this aphorism, giving an appraisal of Wilder's experience that places equal emphasis on the public man and the private thinker, the literary celebrity and the son and brother. The hours Wilder spent in hard study and grinding work are examined with the same attention as the hours of literary hobnobbing that filled his later years, when his best-selling novels and popular plays brought him worldwide fame.

Ms. Niven's deeply researched and fluidly readable book spends much of its first third delving into the relationships among the members of the remarkable family Wilder came from, and to which he remained close throughout his life. Some of the book's most engrossing passages chart the peregrinations of the Wilders during the writer's formative years — years that prepared him, she persuasively argues, for the humane, literate and searching novelist and playwright he would become.

Thornton was the second of five siblings born to Amos Parker Wilder, a domineering father of deeply held Puritan beliefs (including a staunch allegiance to teetotaling) that would sometimes prove troublesome to his peripatetic career. After years as the editor of a financially precarious Wisconsin newspaper, Amos gained a diplomatic appointment in Hong Kong through his Yale connections. But caring for a large family on a diplomat's salary proved difficult, and for much of Thornton Wilder's youth the family was never together for long stretches; often a lack of funds meant even holidays were spent apart.

Letter writing became a tethering lifeline for the family. Along with Amos Parker Wilder's obsessive fussing over his children's education, this early epistolary training surely contributed to one singular development: All five Wilder children became published writers. Amos and Charlotte were primarily poets, Isabel a novelist and the zoologist Janet wrote a book about raising a horse. Only Thornton would

become a renowned figure — Charlotte's failing struggle to earn her living by her pen, which ultimately resulted in a psychological breakdown, makes for painful reading — and when his second novel, "The Bridge of San Luis Rey," became an international phenomenon (winning the first of his Pulitzers) he would eventually take over his father's role as the family's chief breadwinner, supporting his mother, Isabella, and two of his sisters throughout much of their later lives.



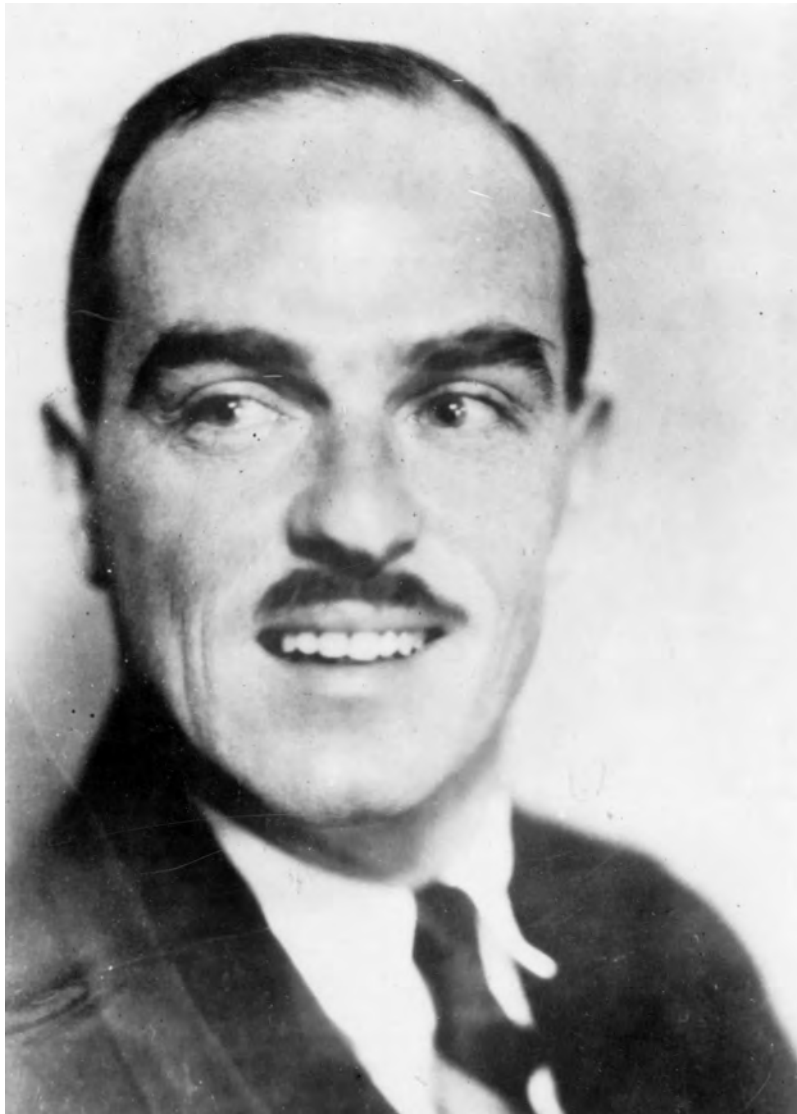
Penelope Niven Louis Kapeleris

Without quite acquiring the glow of a saint — bucking his father's admonitions, Wilder became a steady if not a self-destructive drinker, and he often liked to keep his distance from his family members, love them though he did — the man who emerges from Ms. Niven's fine-grained, sympathetic portrait is remarkable for his easygoing nature, his loyal affections, his generosity of spirit and above all his boundless, enthusiastic foraging in the fields of art and literature.

Wilder's learning was prodigious. He taught Latin and French early in his career and was fluent in German and Italian. Although he is best known today for his theatrical masterworks "Our Town" and "The Skin of Our Teeth," his novels in particular — some set in 18th-century Peru, or ancient Rome and Greece — bespeak a man of thorough classical learning. Late in life, when he might more fruitfully have spent time on his own writings, or basked in the perquisites that rained down on a popular author, he became a virtual expert on decoding James Joyce's "Finnegans Wake," and spent endless hours devoted to dating definitively the plays of the Spanish playwright Lope de Vega.

It cannot be easy to write a biography of a man who lived most deeply inside his questing mind. Yet with the aid of Wilder's journals and letters Ms. Niven is able to make his continuing education a journey that often outshines the more superficially engaging aspects of his career, including friendships with an amazingly disparate array of figures: Gertrude Stein and Alice B. Toklas, the English society hostess Sibyl Colefax, the actress Ruth Gordon, Jean-Paul Sartre and even the prizefighter Gene Tunney, with whom Wilder trekked through Europe when both were more or less at the height of their fame.

Orson Welles and Edward Albee (who provides a brief, kindly foreword) are among the many famous figures who make cameo appearances, along with Ernest Hemingway and F. Scott and Zelda Fitzgerald. (Reading biographies like this one gets the sense that every well-known figure of the 20th century eventually ran into every other well-known figure of the 20th century.)



Thornton Wilder, circa 1940. Hulton Archive/Getty Images

Perhaps understandably in a book this big (800-plus pages) about a life this wide ranging, Ms. Niven's biography flags a bit in the late going, as Wilder's literary output wanes, and is occasionally marred by repetition. Of his novels "Heaven's My Destination" and "Our Town," written in near proximity, she writes that the predominant "myth-themes" are: "How do you live? How do you bear the unbearable? How do you handle the various dimensions of love, of faith, of the human condition? How do universal elements forge every unique, individual human life? And where does the family fit in the cosmic scheme of things?" That doesn't seem to leave much out, aside from maybe the question of how you rub your tummy and pat your head at the same time.

But while it has become commonplace to harp on the universality of great works of literature, Wilder's theatrical masterworks in particular still have the power to inspire awe for the economy with which they do indeed bring together the mundane and the cosmic, the specific, homely detail and the overarching truth.

Few writers have emerged from the crucible of the biographer's attentions in recent years with their reputations as honorable human beings intact. Wilder does. He was not just a great artist, he seems to have been a great man too, in matters both large and small.

Take this beautiful passage from a letter to his sister Isabel, after she had been dropped by the man she had expected to marry and felt her hopes for her life reduced to ashes: "We're all People, before we're anything else. People, even before we're artists. The role of being a Person is sufficient to have lived and died for." He added a bit more mundane but no less generous advice: "Better take a trip to Europe. There's plenty of money."